

THE INDIA PENTECOSTAL CHURCH OF GOD SUNDAY SCHOOL TEXTBOOK

CLASS 13

English

2019



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I.P.C. SUNDAY SCHOOLS ASSOCIATION

SUNDAY SCHOOL TEXT BOOK

Class 13

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PREFACE

Today society is blessed with the most modern innovations of technology but also burdened with curse of immorality and mental depression and no peace. Sunday schools strive to move forward in shaping up a generation that lifts up Jesus through their words and deeds as the only answer to the problems that beset us.

The truth is that the people who influenced the world with their great deeds and contributions all have come from homes that emphasized on spirituality. World-renowned evangelists, mission leaders, theologians and the like are living testimonies of those whose spiritual lives were shaped by their Sunday schools. This text book is prepared by the IPC Sunday Schools Association in its 58th year of existence keeping in mind the changes that have come about in the field of teaching. We have taken the utmost care to strictly adhere to the basic principles of the Word of God, even while bringing about changes that are reflected in the teaching style and method. This book is prepared with much prayer and detailed study of God's Word. We welcome all you fellow teachers to use this book to shape our children to be useful vessels in the Master's hands.

In the ministry of training up children, let us work together with the abundance of God's love to influence these tender minds with the Word of God so that they would be shining lights in this world that they live in.

I present this book with prayer for the glory of God so that it would be a blessing and guide to many thousands of children and families.

Your brother in Christ,

Kumbanad
01-01-2019

Bro. Kurian Joseph
Director

FOREWORD

The aim of the Sunday school is the all-round development of the spiritual, mental, and emotional faculties of our young generation. If this becomes reality, then our children who is our future will be a godly generation. Many great people who have reached the frontiers of mission have accepted Jesus into their lives in the Sunday school. Many world-renowned mission leaders, theologians, and evangelists have been part of I.P.C. because of the strong influence of the Sunday school on their lives.

There is no doubt that this textbook will increase the desire to study God's Word, help in spiritual and moral growth, and in the responsibility towards society for our young children. I request my fellow teachers to approach this textbook with prayer and meditation to prepare a generation of young people for the Lord.

We did not have a textbook that caters to nursery children in the age group of 3-5. This has become a reality. We are also very happy to announce that we are publishing textbooks with pictures and activity-based learning for the primary classes.

We express our heartfelt gratitude to everyone who has contributed immensely for this textbook that will give a bright future to our church. We hope to continue to work with you in the future.

For I.P.C. Sunday Schools Association,

Kumbanad
01-01-2019

Pastor Jose Thomas Jacob
General Secretary

INTRODUCTION

The world today is witness to revolutionary change in many spheres. Information technology has developed rapidly. But atheism, rebellion, immorality and other evils have also increased, making man's future uncertain. In this scenario, our goal is to lead our children to Christ and impart to them a spiritual vision. It was our long-standing dream to bring necessary changes in our textbooks keeping in mind the changes undergone in the field of education. We are happy that it has become a reality. Our desire is to impart the truths of the Word of God in a lucid manner to our children.

The english text book for class 13 is published first time by IPC Sunday School Association of this year (2019). Prophets in Old Testament are the topics included in our curriculum. Special thanks to I.P.C. Sunday Schools Association North American Eastern Region for sponsoring this book.

Your prayer, timely help and suggestions were useful in the past, and we hope that it will continue in the future. We express our heartfelt gratitude and thanks to all those who helped in writing, translating, printing and publishing this book.

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LESSON 1

The Prophets

Objective : To turn back the people from idol worship and to proclaim that there is punishment for those who do not return back to God and that Messiah will come to save a remnant from among the people.

Memory Verse : 2 Peter 1:19-21

And so we have the prophetic word confirmed, which you do well to heed as a light that shines in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts; knowing this first, that no prophecy of Scripture is of any private interpretation, for prophecy never came by the will of man, but holy men of God spoke as they were moved by the Holy Spirit.

Introduction

The Prophets are men of God who were raised up by God himself during the time of Israel's backsliding. They were patriots who proclaimed to the people about God and inspired in them a divine consciousness. Their message was divinely inspired and was relevant to the local and circumstantial situation of the people. They lacked the vision of a New Testament Church (a gathering of people from all the nations). Their vision was mainly on the future hope of Israel and its restoration. A major part of the message was based on Immanuel (Messiah), the son of David. They present two facets of Christ, the Son of David, the Son of Abraham – (1) Suffering Christ (2) Christ, the King. To many of the prophets, the vision of the suffering Christ is not clearly identified. But the New Testament make it very clear (The mystery of the suffering Christ before he comes as the ruler was partially hidden to the Old Testament prophets).

The prophetic books can be divided into three parts

1. Pre-exilic prophets (Isaiah, Jeremiah, Hosea, Joel, Amos, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah)
2. Exilic prophets (Ezekiel, Daniel, Obadiah)
3. Post-exilic prophets (Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi)

Taking into consideration, the length of each of the prophetic books, it has been divided into two: (a) Major Prophets – Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel and Daniel (4 Prophets, 5 Books) and (b) Minor Prophets – Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah and Malachi (12 Prophets). This division is not based on the time of their ministry. The prophets prophesied for a period of 400 years (B.C. 800-400).

Prophets	Timeline	Message
1. Pre-exilic Prophets		
Joel	B.C. 850 – 700	The Gospel Age and the Coming Together of the Gentile Nations
Jonah	B.C. 800	God's Sovereignty – Compassion and Mercy – even on the Enemies of Israel
Amos	B.C. 756 - 755	The House of David shall yet rule the world
Hosea	B.C. 760 - 710	The day Yahweh shall be God of all
Micah	B.C. 740	The Prince of Bethlehem – the Sovereign Ruler of all
Isaiah	B.C. 740 - 680	The Bright Future of the Remnant of the People of God

Nahum	B.C. 666 - 615	The Judgement soon to fall on Nineveh
Zephaniah	B.C. 630 - 620	New Name - New Revelation
Habakkuk	B.C. 627 – 586	Ultimate Victory to the people of God
Jeremiah	B.C. 627 - 580	The Sin of Jerusalem – Judgement - Bright Future

2. Exilic Prophets

Daniel	B.C. 605 – 535	Four Empires – God’s Eternal Kingdom
Ezekiel	B.C. 598 – 570	The Fall of Jerusalem – Restoration – and its Great Future
Obadiah	B.C. 585	The Complete of Edom

3. Post-Exilic Prophets

Haggai	B.C. 520	The Second Temple – Coming of a Greater Temple
Zechariah	B.C. 520 - 518	The Coming King – His Household, the Nation
Malachi	B.C. 450 - 400	The Last Message before the coming of the Messiah

Though the prophets themselves did not understand the futuristic messages they gave, God was conveying the story of the Messiah (Christ) to the people.

The priests ministered according to the Order of their families. Some of them also did prophetic ministries. But the prophets did not minister (prophecy) according to familial order. God ordained prophets, from different walks of life, to deliver the people from their sinful ways. Jeremiah, Ezekiel and Zechariah were of priestly families while Isaiah, Daniel and Zephaniah belonged to the ruling families and yet again Amos was a shepherd. We have little knowledge about the background of the other prophets.

They fought with zeal against the political, social, national and spiritual evils prevalent during their times. They were preachers of righteousness and leaders of reformation in their society. All major writers of the Old Testament were considered prophets, starting from Moses. Several prophets from Enoch, Noah, Abraham, Moses, Samuel, Elijah, Elisha till Malachi served the Lord as prophets.

The word “Prophet” means the one who conveys God’s will through divine motivation. There are different words used for prophets in the Hebrew language – ‘Nabi’, ‘Hozeh’, ‘Roah’ (I Chro. 29:29). (Samuel, the ‘Roah’; Nathan, the ‘Nabi’; Gad, the ‘Hozeh’). It is difficult to differentiate between the three terms. ‘Nabi’ is a messenger, ‘Hozeh’ is a seer of visions, ‘Roah’ is ambassador, shepherd, motivator, are some of the meanings of the terms. It is usually thought that the position of ‘Roah’ is higher than that of ‘Nabi’ and ‘Hozeh’. All the three names are used for the term prophets in the Old Testament.

Due to the presence of the true prophets, false prophets did not find place in Israel (Deut. 18:15). We find prophetic ministries and schools of prophets in the Scripture. These schools of prophets may have been in place to educate the prophets in the interpretation of scriptures and scriptural truths. There was no unification of dress code or mannerisms for the prophets. The common factor that we see among the prophets were that they lived a life of self-denial. They tried to establish cordial relationship between God and man and also between man and man.

Method of Prophetic Interpretation.

1. In relation to the Millennial era – Pre-Millennial, Millennial or Post-Millennial
2. The rule of **historical background** - Understand the historical background of the prophecy. No small historical fact is unimportant.
3. The rule of **context**: The meaning must be gathered from the context. Every word you read must be understood in the light of the words that come before and after it. Many passages will not be understood at all, or understood incorrectly, without the help afforded by the context.. Unless we know the context of the prophecy, we cannot properly interpret the prophecy.

4. A text should be inter-pret-ed with due respect for the literary structure and style of the larger passage of which it is a part. We need to understand the literal meaning of the word as well its figurative meaning before interpreting a prophetic word. Do not interpret a prophecy without taking into consideration the basic scriptural truths.
5. The rule of **logic**: Interpretation is merely logical reasoning. When interpreting Scripture, the use of reason is everywhere to be assumed. Does the interpretation make sense? The Bible was given to us in the form of human language and therefore appeals to human reason – it invites investigation. It is to be interpreted as we would any other volume: applying the laws of language and grammatical analysis.
6. Each prophet has his own style of presentation. God uses the presentation skill of the prophet to convey his message. These too have to be taken into consideration.
7. Strengthening the believers in the present, and rectifying the past and thereby striving for a bright future
8. These ten rules presented in such a way that both the hearer and the interpreter clearly understand the message
9. Interpretation should be enhancing, thought provoking and exhorting. For example, the Hebrew method of reading the scripture was poetic in nature and so it remained in the minds of the people and they were able to contemplate on the verses.
10. The Messianic story – from birth of the Messiah to the final rapture and eternity, the futuristic behaviour of the Jews, the Church and the Gentile nations are all very clearly mentioned in the prophecy

Prophets and the Nations to which prophesied

Israel – Amos, Hosea; Nineveh – Jonah, Nahum; Babylon – Daniel; Exiles in Babylon – Ezekiel; Edom – Obadiah; Judah – Joel, Isaiah, Micah, Jeremiah, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi.

Questions

1. Describe the purpose of Prophecy in a few words?
2. To how many parts can the prophetic books divided? Which are they? Name the books?
3. Name the Hebrew words that denote prophet? Describe their meaning?
4. What are the rules to be kept in mind when interpreting prophecy?
5. Mention in brief – “The time and message of the prophets”?
6. Names the nations to whom the prophets prophesied?

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LESSON 1-A

Isaiah

Objective : To prepare ourselves for the Messianic Kingdom by studying the Book of Isaiah also called ‘the Old Testament Gospel’ and thereby escaping from the judgement to come.

Memory Verse : Isaiah 9:6 , Isaiah 53:6

Isaiah 9:6 : For unto us a Child is born, Unto us a Son is given; And the government will be upon His shoulder. And His name will be called Wonderful, Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.

Isaiah 53:6: All we like sheep have gone astray; We have turned, every one, to his own way; And the Lord has laid on Him the iniquity of us all.

Introduction

The name 'Isaiah' is derived from the words 'YeshaYahu' which means 'Yahweh will Save' or 'Yahweh is Salvation'. This book is called by different names – 'Book of Salvation', 'The Miniature Bible', 'The Old Testament Gospel', 'The Fifth Gospel' while the writer (Isaiah) is known as 'The Redeeming Prophet', 'The Master of Old Testament Prophecy', 'The Messianic Prophet', and as 'The Old Testament Paul'.

This book is called the miniature bible based on its structure and the number of chapters. Just as the Bible has 66 books, so also the Book of Isaiah has 66 chapters. 39 chapters conveys the messages as we see in the Old Testament and 27 chapters conveys the New Testament messages of grace and hope as well as proclaim the gospel.

Isaiah prophesied during the reign of Uzziah (B.C. 787-735), Jotham (749-847), Ahaz (744-726), Hezekiah (726-697). During the reign of King Hezekiah, Sennacherib, King of Assyria, attacked Jerusalem. But he was miraculously overcome, through the power of prayer. Till his death, he could not gain enough strength to fight Jerusalem again. During the reign of Manasseh (697 – 642), Isaiah was a critic of the idol worship encouraged by the king. As a result, Isaiah suffered martyrdom – he was killed by chain saw (cut into two using the chain saw – Heb. 11:37).

Isaiah was the prophet of Judah, the southern kingdom. He witnessed the destruction of Israel, the northern kingdom at the hands of the Assyrians. Though he received the call to the service of God as a prophet during the time of Uzziah, it is believed that he got a reconfirmation to the ministry after the King's death (6:1). Isaiah's father was Amoz (not the prophet Amos). Amoz was the brother of Amaziah. So Isaiah was a relative of King Uzziah, and so was of royalty. The largest threat faced by Judah was from the Assyrian Empire. The Assyrian empire came into prominence 150 years before Isaiah. The wife of Prophet Isaiah is called a prophetess (may be because of being the wife of a prophet). He had two sons – Shear-jashub (a remnant will return – 7:3) and Maher-shalal-hash-baz (Judgement shall soon come – 8:3). There are instances when the prophet Isaiah wore sack cloths and walked barefoot (20:1).

There are mention of literary writings by prophet Isaiah –Uzziah’s biography (2 Chro. 26:22), Hezekiah’s biography (2 Chro. 32:32), but we have not found these works.

It is commonly believed that the original manuscripts of the Bible are lost and what has been handed down us are the copies of the original that the scribes have written down. In 1947, among the dead sea scrolls, a 2000 year old manuscript of the book of Isaiah was found. It was the oldest manuscript. It was 24 feet long and was a collection of 10x15 inch papyrus sewed together with each other and then rolled and put in jars for safe keeping. It was a gem of a find for bible scholars as well as bible believers.

This manuscript is known as ‘Yeshaiah’ in Hebrew, ‘Hesaias’ in Greek and as ‘Esaias’ and ‘Isaias’ in Latin.

Author

The Author is Isaiah. It is commonly believed that there were two Isaiah who wrote the book. First Isaiah wrote chapters 1 to 39 and the second Isaiah wrote chapters 40 to 66. One depicted Messiah as the ‘King’ while the other depicted Messiah as the ‘Suffering Servant’. Yet this is not considered logical due to the fact that the literary style, language and presentations are same through out the book. The Book of Ecclesiastes, Septuagint, Talmud and certain other writers all point to one Isaiah.

New Testament Quotes

John 12:37-41 (Isa. 53:1, 6:9-10)

Rom. 9:27; 10:15-21 (Isa.10: 22-23; 28:22; 52:7; 53:1; 65:1, 2)

Matthew 3:3; 8:17; 12:17-21 (Isa. 40:3; Isa. 53:4; Isa. 42:1-4)

Luke 3:4-6; Acts 8:32-33 (Isa. 40:3-5; 53:7-8)

Old Testament Quotes

Jere. 10:1-6 = Isa. 41:7; 44:12-15

Zeph. 2:15 = Isa. 47:8,10

Period of Writing – BC 740 – 680

Isaiah has not prophesied about the Babylonian exile. Though he prophesied about Cyrus, yet there was no mention of the return (44:45). It is believed that Isaiah ministered 150 years before the exile. He ministered from around BC 740 to BC 680 (1:1). This was the period when Assyria under Tiglath Pileser, was very strong and while he was conquering neighboring nations (BC 745 – 727), Isaiah was ministering in Judah. Later, under the leadership of Sennacherib, Assyria attacked Judah and laid siege to Jerusalem (BC 705-681). During this time Isaiah prophesied to Judah and reminded them ‘It is better to trust in the Lord than trust in man’. Though Isaiah lived in Judah, the southern kingdom, yet he prophesied about the northern kingdom of Israel. He did not minister after the reign of Hezekiah. He was killed (martyred) during the reign of Manasseh.

Christ in Isaiah – fulfilment

*No war, no idol worship, Rule of God		Isa. 2:4; 65:25
Rule the Nations		2:2-3; 42:1-6; 55:4-5; 56:6; 60:3-8
Virgin Birth	7:14	Matt. 1:22-23
Minister in Galilee	9:1-2	Matt. 4:12-16
*Eternal Throne	9:5-7	Luke 2:11; Eph. 2:14-18
Shoot of the stump of Jesse – branch	11:1	Luke 3:30; Acts 13:22, 23
The Spirit of the Lord on him	11:2	Luke 3:22
Death, sorrow, wipe away all tears,	25:5-8;	Acts 26:19 – 23
Resurrection		
Strong foundation	28:16	1 Pet. 2:4-6
*His method of reign	32:1-8	6:1-11; 40:10,11
His forerunner	40:3-5	Matt. 3:1-3

Yahweh's Servant, Elect	42:1-7	Matt. 12:15-21; Luke 2:29,32
Scorned, beat and beard plucked out	50:6	Matt. 26:67; 27:26,30
Appearance disfigured, did not look like a man – humbleness	52:14	Phil. 2:7-11
Despised and rejected	53:3	John 1:11, 7:5; Luke 23:18
Punished for our iniquities & transgressions	53:4,5	Rom. 5:6,8
Death along with the wicked, buried with the rich	53:9,12	Matt.27:57-60; Mark 15:28
Good news to the poor, heal the broken hearted, freedom to the prisoners *New heavens and new earth will appear	61:1, 2 65:17	Luke 4:17, 19, 21 66:22
Will separate the righteous and the wicked eternally	66:15	Matt. 25:32

*Prophecies yet to be fulfilled – Prophecies in Verses – 4:2; 11:2-6, 10; 32:1-8; 49:7; 52:13, 15; 59:20, 21; 60:2,3 – are yet to be fulfilled. Of the 300 prophecies in the Old Testament in relation to the first coming of Jesus Christ, a large portion of these prophecies can be seen in Isaiah.

Verses of Isaiah 52:13 – 53:12 can be divided into 5 parts based on 5 important aspects of Christ's sacrifice on the cross.

1. 52:13-15 Christ's complete sacrifice
Burnt Offering
2. 53:1-3 Christ's complete nature
Grain Offering

- | | | |
|----|----------|--|
| 3. | 53:4-6 | Christ's complete peace
Peace Offering |
| 4. | 53:7-8 | Christ's complete deliverance
from sin Sin Offering |
| 5. | 53:10-12 | Christ's deliverance from
Guilt Offering all transgressions
and iniquities |

The word 'Salvation' or its variant is found 26 times in the book of Isaiah, while all the other prophets together use it 7 times.

Division based on Salvation

Chapters 1-39 Necessity of Salvation

Chapters 40-66 Way of Salvation

Main Message

The good news (Gospel) of Christ – Salvation – Punishment

Outline of the Book

We can divide this book into three parts based on the subject matter

- | | | |
|--------------------------|---|----------------|
| 1. Prophecy of Judgement | – | Chapters 1-35 |
| 2. Historical Events | – | Chapters 36-39 |
| 3. Prophecy of Comfort | – | Chapters 40-66 |

1. Prophecy of Judgement (Chapters 1-35)

The first Chapter can be considered an introduction to what follows. Chapters 1-12 point to the judgement on Judah. Their custom and their practices are just outward appearances of their godliness. In Chapter 6, God is asking them to repent. After this comes the prophecies on 'Immanuel' (Chapters 7 – 12), Messianic messages (7:14; 8:14; 9:2,6,7; 11:1,2) and the blessings while the Messiah reigns.

Then we see judgement on surrounding enemy nations (total 11 nations) – Babylon, Assyria, Philistia, Moab, Damascus (Syria), Ethiopia, Egypt (Mizraim), Edom, Arabia, Tyre and Jerusalem (Judah).

Chapters 24-27 talks about the faithlessness of Judah. After punishment, there is blessings (28-33). Prophecy on six types of judgement for sins and it will come on all the nations and then blessing is seen in chapters 34 and 35.

2. Historical Events (Chapters 36-39)

In BC 701, Assyria tries to conquer Judah, but later on Judah falls to Babylon (Chs. 36, 37; 2 Kings 18:19). The Assyrian King, Sennacherib, came to attack Judah during the time of Hezekiah. God saved the land. Later Hezekiah is healed. His life is extended for 15 more years. He shows his wealth to the Babylonian emissaries. Later Babylon attacks Judah and captures it. Though the land was saved from the Assyrians yet fell to the Babylonians (Chs. 38 – 39).

3. Prophecy of Comfort (Chapters 40-66)

Prophecies of comfort are given after punishments are pronounced. Godly reign is the basis of all comfort (40-46). Of the 216 verses in these chapters, 115 of them points to the powerfulness of God. There is a comparative study on the Creator God and the uselessness of idols. The eternal nature of God is clearly pictured. There is promise of deliverance from the Babylonian exile. There is a proclamation that the Persian King Cyrus will help build the Temple in Jerusalem (44-45). This prophecy was said 150 years before Cyrus was born and it was later fulfilled. After the rebuilding and restoration from chs. 49 to 57, we find Messianic prophecy. The Messiah is depicted as Saviour, King and the Suffering Servant. There is also promise of the gathering of Jews from all over the world, back into their own country. One who believes and trusts shall be saved. Chs. 58 to 66 point to the rebuilding of Jerusalem. Messiah will rule, enemies will be punished. There is peace and prosperity and joy everywhere. God will restore – The new heavens and the new earth.

This book consists of 66 chapters and 1292 verses.

Questions

1. Why is the book of Isaiah called a miniature bible?
2. Who were the rulers of Judah during the time of Isaiah?
3. Describe the history of Isaiah in a paragraph.
4. Which are the other writings of Isaiah?
5. Write a short note on 'Dead Sea Scrolls'.
6. Write on the Authorship of the book. How do you confirm it is Isaiah?
7. When did Isaiah write his prophecies? What are the historical facts?
8. Write an essay on 'Christ in the Book of Isaiah'.
9. Give an outline on the 'Prophecy of Isaiah'.

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LESSON 2

Jeremiah

Objective : To return back to God through repentance from a backslidden state. They will receive a new heart and a new covenant. If not, God will deal harshly. Even though you have to suffer, to convey this message, do not be hesitant.

Memory Verse :

Jeremiah 7:23,24 : But this is what I commanded them, saying, 'Obey My voice, and I will be your God, and you shall be My people. And walk in all the ways that I have commanded you, that it may be well with you.' Yet they did not obey or incline their ear, but followed the counsels and the dictates of their evil hearts, and went backward and not forward.

Jeremiah 8:11,12 - For they have healed the hurt of the daughter of My people slightly, Saying, 'Peace, peace!' When there is no peace. Were they ashamed when they had committed

abomination? No! They were not at all ashamed, Nor did they know how to blush. Therefore they shall fall among those who fall; In the time of their punishment They shall be cast down,” says the Lord.

Jeremiah 31:33 - But this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, says the Lord: I will put My law in their minds, and write it on their hearts; and I will be their God, and they shall be My people.

Introduction

This prophecy is the final effort of God to save Jerusalem. Jeremiah prophesied 100 years after Isaiah. Isaiah was able to help overcome Assyria and so save Jerusalem but Jeremiah could not do it against Babylon. He had God’s calling in BC 626. It was during the 13 year of King Josiah. It was also during the time of revival. Jerusalem was destroyed partially in BC 606 and completely in BC 586. Jeremiah lived for 40 years through this tumultuous period. Kingly rule was completely wiped out. That was the death pangs of the nation. During this time when impurity and idol worship took the upper hand, prophet Jeremiah sorrowfully proclaimed God’s commands to the people. Yet the people did not turn back. And so God allowed the Babylonian exile.

The era was one in which Assyria, Babylon and Egypt were striving with each other for world dominance. Assyria, with its capital city as ‘Nineveh’ on the banks of river Euphrates, ruled the world for ‘300’ years. Egypt, on the banks of river Nile ruled the world for a 1000 years and fell. Later it revived. Babylon, overcame these empires, took world dominance. It was during this time that Jeremiah prophesied. In BC 607, Babylon defeated Assyria and in BC 605, overcame Egypt in the battle at Carchemish. They ruled for 70 years and all these times Judah was in exile in Babylon.

Twenty years before Babylonian exile, Jeremiah prophesied about the coming disaster, yet they were not willing to heed it. Jeremiah exhorted the rulers to surrender before Babylon and not resist it. The people of Judah misunderstood Jeremiah and he was persecuted. Ultimately, Babylon conquered Judah. Nebuchadnezzar was pleased with

Jeremiah and wanted to honor him. When Jerusalem was completely destroyed, Jeremiah was given the option to either stay in Jerusalem among the poor or to go with the king to Babylon. Jeremiah decided to stay on in Jerusalem. But when the governor Gedaliah was killed (41:7), the rest fled to Egypt. They took with them Jeremiah and his writer Baruch (43:6-7). Even in Egypt, Jeremiah continued to prophecy and exhorted the people to turn back to God (Ch.44). Jeremiah also proclaimed that after 70 years, Judah shall return from exile and that Babylon shall be judged and completely destroyed (23:5-8; 25:1-4; 11, 12; 29:10; 39:11-12; chs 50, 51).

Jeremiah was born during the reign of Manasseh, and after the reign of Amon, during the thirteenth year of the reign of Josiah, he received the heavenly calling. He continued to minister during the reign of Jehoahaz, Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin and Zedekiah. Later he was taken to Egypt and it is believed that he died there.

Contemporary prophets – Ezekiel (prophesied among the exiles of Babylon), Daniel (prophesied in the palace at Babylon), Habakkuk, Zephaniah (prophesied along with Jeremiah in Jerusalem), Nahum (prophesied the fall of Nineveh), Obadiah (prophesied about Edom).

The book is not arranged chronologically as a whole, although some chronological order is apparent. Some prophecies have dates. Some do not. The prophecies all seem to be mixed up when looking at the order of the events. Jeremiah prophesied and Baruch, later wrote it down and may be that is the reason for the seeming mix up. There are also events written down in between prophecies. Though Baruch gave the written prophecies in a scroll to king Jehoiakim, he tore it up and threw it in the fire. And so Baruch had to write it again. And so the book does not follow any particular chronological order (36:32).

Jeremiah, a young prophet of the priestly class, is the son of Hilkiah, living in Anathoth. Jeremiah is known as the weeping prophet. Prophets who have suffered persecution from their own people are very rare, but Jeremiah is one of them. Hilkiah, mentioned in 2 Kings 22:8, is believed to be Jeremiah's father (Eleazar, Zadok, Ithamar, Hilkiah, Jeremiah). As a youth, he stayed in Anathoth. But he was persecuted and so he moved to Jerusalem.

The book carries the name of the prophet himself. In Hebrew language, the book is known as ‘Yirmeyahu’, or ‘Yirmeyah’. The meaning of the word is ‘Yahweh uplifts’, ‘God exalts’. The Greek term is ‘Jeremis’ and the Latin term is ‘Jeremias’.

Author

The author is Jeremiah, the priest, son of Hilkiah (1:1). He was born in Anathoth, 2 miles north of Jerusalem. He was a celibate (bachelor-16:2). He was unique prophet. He faced persecution from the common man, priests, other prophets and also from kings. It is believed that of the 52 chapters, Jeremiah wrote a major portion, the rest was done by Baruch (2 Kings 24:18 – 25:30). Jeremiah had dictated to Baruch what to write.

We find a quote from Jeremiah in Daniel 9:2, (25:11-14, 29:10). The events in 2 Chro. 36:21 and Neh. 1:1 are those that happened in Jeremiah’s lifetime. Josephus, the historian, mentions that Jeremiah prophesied about the destruction of Jerusalem. We have quotes in the New Testament from this book – Matt. 2:17-18 (Jer.31:15); Matt. 21:13; Mk 11:17; Luke 19:46 (Jer. 7:11); Rom. 11:27 (Jer. 31:31-34); Heb. 8:8-13 (Jer. 31:31-34). Paul has quoted from Jeremiah and the church fathers believed that this book was written by Jeremiah himself.

Date

From the time of King Josiah to the reign of the last five kings of Judah (40 years).

Christ in Jeremiah

The message of Messiah is prevalent through out the book, in the ministry and persecution faced by the prophet.

Christ, the Shepherd, the righteous Branch (Jer. 2:31-8). He is the king who works justice and judgement. During his rule, Judah will be saved. His name is ‘The Lord, our righteousness’ (Jer.23:56), He will fulfill the covenants made with Abraham, Moss and David (Gen. 12:1-3; 17:1-8; Deut. 28-30; 2 Sam. 7:1-17).

Jehoiakim is considered cursed (22:28- 30). And so in the list of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, we don't find Jehoiakim but another son of David, Nathan (Matt. 1:1-17; Luke 3:23-38; 3:31). Thus the genealogy of Joseph and Mary was listed.

This points to the Messianic restoration of Israel (23: 5-7; 30:3-11; 31:31-34; 33:15-18). David's righteous Branch; Lord, our Righteousness (23:5-6; 30:9). This will find fulfillment in the millennial rule. From Rom. 11:15- 29 we find the fulfilment of Messiah rule.

Main Theme

The final call to repentance for all the people. The prophet make the last attempt to save Jerusalem.

Perspective of the book

The five warnings that the Prophet Jeremiah gave to the people:

1. Babylon will attack and subjugate Judah
2. If Judah repents and turns back to God, he will deliver Judah from the hands of Babylonians.
3. The Babylonians will take groups of people at deterrent times to Babylon and thereby break unity
4. Though Judah is destroyed, yet will it rise again and gain supremacy.
5. Babylon will fall and never rise again.

Jeremiah's ministry can be divided into three parts

1. BC. 627 – 605 – Threat faced by Judah from Assyria and Egypt
2. BC. 605 – 586 -- Threat from Babylon and Subjugation
3. BC. 586 – 580 – Egyptian subjugation, Babylonian exile

Judah is in the last part of the clock. The picture of the potter rejecting the clay in his hands (18:1-4)

In this book, there is 164 warnings of the impending Babylonian exile which the prophet gave in his 40 years ministry. As a result, the

prophet faced persecution. Jeremiah wanted to even give up the prophetic ministry (9:1; 13:17).

Though there is no chronological arrangement yet the message of salvation is described very clearly for which repentance and submission is very much needed.

Outline of the Book

1. Calling of Jeremiah Ch. 1
2. Prophecy to Judah Chs 2– 45
3. Prophecy to the Gentiles Chs 46 – 51
4. Fall of Jerusalem Ch 52

Calling of Jeremiah

Jeremiah was designated before his birth, and separated to be a prophet.

Beginning – uniqueness

Prophecy to Judah

Gave messages using parables, visual lessons and outright messages. His own life was an example.

Visual lessons

13:1-4; 14:1-9; 16:1-9; 18:1-3; 19:1-13; 24:1-10; 27:1-11; 32:6-15; 43:8-13

12 messages were given to Judah at a stretch. All the messages were of judgement. They were not faithful to God. And so God rejected them. They continued in iniquity. Jeremiah was a celibate (unmarried, bachelor). He did not participate in many of their festivals. They disregarded the Sabbath and the temple worship. And so God sent them to a land with none of these. Jeremiah prophesied that the duration of the exile will be 70 years. So enemies were ready to kill him. He visualized the exile before the people by putting on a yoke on his neck. The remnant who turns back to God will receive a new law and a new blessing. Jeremiah was put out of the temple. Jeremiah sent Baruch to

the king with the prophecies written on a scroll. Jehoiakim burnt the scroll. Jeremiah was imprisoned. After the destruction of Jerusalem, he went to Egypt and continued to prophecy.

Prophecy to the Gentiles

He prophesied against some nations – Egypt, Philistia, Moab, Ammon, Edom, Damascus (Syria), Arabia, Elim and Babylon. To some of these nations , he also gave promises of restoration and also gave encouraging messages to Egypt, Moab, Ammon and Elim.

The fall of Jerusalem

The fall of Jerusalem that Jeremiah, prophesied during his 40 year ministry is given in 4 places in the scripture (2 Kings 25; 2 Chro. 36 ; Jeremiah 39; 52). In the fourth part, Jerusalem is captured, destroyed, subjugated and the king is executed and the rest taken to exile in Babylon.

In this book, there are 52 chapters and 1364 verses.

Questions:

1. What is the main theme of Jeremiah's prophecy?
2. Isaiah and Jeremiah struggled to save the land from foreign occupation. What was the result?
3. Which are the nations that strove for supremacy during the time of Jeremiah? What was the end-result?
4. What is the importance of the Carchemish war?
5. When was Jerusalem totally destroyed? What were the reasons?
6. Who were the contemporary prophets and kings of Jeremiah?
7. Why was there no chronological order of events in the book of Jeremiah?
8. Who was Jeremiah's helper and writer? Why did Jehoiakim burn the scrolls?
9. Write an essay on the Christ we find in this book.
10. Christ was not born as a descendant of Jehoiakim, why?
11. Write a summary on the book.

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LESSON 3

Lamentations

Objective : If divine warnings are not heeded, then there will be Godly wrath. If the people who are called to be a blessing, become shamed, the real devotees will weep and intercede. Then we will see God's faithfulness.

Memory Verse :

Lam. 2:5,6: The Lord was like an enemy. He has swallowed up Israel, He has swallowed up all her palaces; He has destroyed her strongholds, And has increased mourning and lamentation In the daughter of Judah. He has done violence to His tabernacle, As if it were a garden; He has destroyed His place of assembly; The Lord has caused The appointed feasts and Sabbaths to be forgotten in Zion. In His burning indignation He has spurned the king and the priest.

Lam. 3:22,23 - Through the Lord's mercies we are not consumed, Because His compassions fail not. They are new every morning; Great is Your faithfulness.

Introduction

This is a lamentation of the prophet Jeremiah regarding Jerusalem. There are five poems arranged in the order of the Hebrew alphabets. They are separated into paragraphs with 22 verses each (just like Psalms 119).

First two chapters have 22 verses each (Hebrew language has 22 verses). The third chapter has a total of 66 verses, with three verses under each alphabet ($22 \times 3 = 66$ verses). The fourth chapter follows the order of the first two chapters. Though the fifth chapter has 22 verses, we don't find the alphabetical order. The book of lamentations follow the 'qinah' style of poetry. There are three divisions, of which the first

one is longer than the other two. This is done to express sorrow. The verses start with 'Alpha' and ends with 'Omega'.

Jerusalem, once a majestic city has been turned into a dunghill, at the hands of the Babylonians. The book of Lamentations is a reaction to this plight. In the midst of this lamentation, the prophet declares the faithfulness of God (3:23). Through his own experience, Jeremiah points out that God is never defeated. In all his troubles, Jeremiah continues to trust, hope, love and finds comfort in God.

This book is part of the 'Megilloth' (Writings), the third portion of the Hebrew canon.

The last chapter of Jeremiah's lamentation is actually the introduction. This is included in the Hagiographa.

The books of Ruth, Ruth, Lamentations, Ecclesiastes, Esther, and Song of Songs are the books included in the writings called 'Megilloth', the third portion of the Hebrew bible. The book of Lamentations is read in the 9th day of the 4th month, in all synagogues.

It is believed that Jeremiah sung this lament (Grotto) at the north wall of Jerusalem with great grief. This is compared to the experience of Christ at Golgotha. It is believed that Christ was crucified, suffered and died at the same place that the prophet raised the lament.

The first division of each verse (the longer one) that we find in the 1st, 2nd and 4th chapters are called 'Ekah'.

'Ah, how' means 'oh no' in the Hebrew language. Another word 'Ginoth' means 'lament'. We can see these words in the book. The Greek word "Threoi" means 'lament' and 'shed tears'. In the Latin vulgate, the book is called 'Ldest lamentations Jeremiae Prophetarum'. It is from this that the English term, 'The lamentations of Jeremiah' came into usage.

Author

It is believed that prophet Jeremiah is the author. There are others who doubt the authorship of Jeremiah. They argue that during the days of Jeremiah, the practise of lamenting (poetry) in such manner was absent. The practise started 300 years after Jeremiah. Yet the similarity between the writings of Jeremiah and the book of Lamentations give weightage

to the idea of authorship of Jeremiah. If the prophet's authorship is denied, then we have no knowledge of any other source of authorship to which it can be attributed to. The style of writing can have change according to the purpose of writing.

Church fathers have attributed the authorship to Jeremiah. There are enough evidence, both internal as well as well as external, to prove his authorship. The events alluded to in Lamentations has happened during the days of Jeremiah and he might have been a witness. Moreover, the ideas in lamentations and the writings of Jeremiah are similar.

External Evidence

The Judea-Christian tradition attributes this book to Jeremiah. It is written in the Septuagint (LXX), "When Jeremiah saw the destruction done to Jerusalem, after the people have been taken as exiles, he lamented..."

In 2 Chro. 35:25, it is written that Jeremiah lamented about Josiah, the king, provides proof that the practise of raising a lamentation (poetic dirge) was present during the times of the prophet.

Internal Evidence

The author of this book is a witness to the destruction at Jerusalem (1:13-15; 2:6,9; 4:1-12). Jeremiah is also a witness (Jer. Ch. 39). There is unity between the book Jeremiah and the book of Lamentations.

Lam. 1:2 – Jer. 30:14

Lam. 1:15 – Jer.8:21

Lam. 2:16; 2:1 – Jer. 9:1,18

Lam. 2:22 – Jer. 6:25

Lam. 4:21 – Jer. 49:12

The fall of Judah and the grief are mentioned in both of them.

Date – BC 6

The book may have been written in 3 months after the total destruction of Jerusalem (burning) and the people taken as captives

(Jer. 39:2; 41:1,18; 43:7). Mizpah was the headquarters at the time (Jer. 40:8). It is commonly thought that a major portion of the book was written at Mizpah and the rest either in Egypt or in Babylon and the exiles sang it to remember their exile and return.

Historicity

It was written during the lifetime of Jeremiah. The book was written after the destruction of Jerusalem (Jer. 39:52) and so it was the beginning of the exile. The siege and subjugation of Jerusalem at the hands of Nebuchadnezzar happened between BC 588 (January) to BC 586 (July). Jerusalem fell on July 19th. The city and the temple were burnt on Aug. 15th. It is believed that Jeremiah wrote the five laments before the people were taken into exile to Babylon. While some of the people were taken to Babylon, others fled to Egypt (Jer. 43).

Christ in Lamentations

The weeping prophet symbolises Christ. Christ also wept for Jerusalem, six centuries later (Matt. 23:31, 38). Jeremiah suffered with the exiles and wept for them. Just as Jeremiah, Christ was also a ‘man of sorrow’. He was persecuted in life, death and in ministry (1:2; 3:19), rejected and oppressed (12:5,16; 3:14,30).

Main theme

There are three main themes in the five poems of Jeremiah’s lamentations.

1. One of the main themes is about the great suffering and destruction of Jerusalem. It was foretold through the prophet of the coming devastation. He grieves over the exiles. The destruction of the city is symbolic to the life of the exiles.
2. It is the justice and judgement of God over Judah that led to the repentance and the grief of the prophet.
3. In the midst of suffering, Jeremiah brings out the future hope and restoration to the people of God. He proclaims the mercy and faithfulness of God and reminds the people of the promise of restoration.

Summary of Lamentation

This book is a beacon of hope amidst destruction. It raises a tower of hope in the midst of darkness and dejection (chs. 1,2,3,4,5 – 3:22-25).

Jeremiah had to undergo suffering and hardships because of his message. He was rejected. But at last, just as he foretold, destruction came. In BC 586, Nebuchadnezzar came and destroyed Jerusalem. This is the lamentation of death of Jerusalem. The prophet weeps for the sinners and those who perished as a result. The city, the temple, the palace, the wall – all were destroyed and became dunghill. The people were taken into exile. His five songs can be divided into:

1. Destruction of Jerusalem
2. Wrath of God
3. Prayer for mercy
4. Exile after the devastation
5. Prayer for restoration

1. Destruction of Jerusalem (1:1-11)

A lament over Jerusalem and the people who represent it (1:12-22). A cry over the destruction as a result of sin. Enemy nations mock Jerusalem (1:7). A lament over Jerusalem and a cry for justice over the enemies.

2. Wrath of God

In the second lament also, the destruction is reminded. Babylon was used as an instrument to punish Jerusalem. The lament of Jeremiah is that of a witness. Babylon came and put a stop to all sacrifices and temple traditions – the priests, the prophets, the kings, and the temple – all ended. It was the result of opposition to God. This chapter closes with a cry for mercy and restoration.

3. Prayer for mercy

The first 18 verses in the 3rd chapter is of sorrow and dejection. Verses 19- 39 points to God's faithfulness and mercy. This thought gives

him hope amidst the suffering all around. Jeremiah pleads for a redemption from their destructions.

4. Exile after the devastation (Chapter 4)

Jeremiah takes up a lament over the people both the poor and the rich. Considers the reason for the exile. He examines the ways of the prophets and the priests, their sins and ways of life and also the lack of trust in God as the subject of his lament. He foretells the future of Edom and also the future hope of Jerusalem.

5. Prayer for restoration (Chapter 3)

This is a lament over the sorrow of the people. Since the people have suffered for their sins, the prophet is praying for restoration.

This book has 5 chapters and 154 verses

Questions

1. Explain the uniqueness of the book.
2. Why does the prophet say “God’s faithfulness is great”
3. To which division does the book of lamentations belong to? What is its importance?
4. Why is the book called ‘the book of lamentation’?
5. Prove that Jeremiah is the author of this book.
6. Write a paragraph on the date and historicity of this book.
7. Write a paragraph on ‘Christ in lamentations’.
8. Write a summary on lamentations

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LESSON 4

Ezekiel

Objective : Through judgement and suffering, God makes the people understand the truth – ‘They will know, I am God’ – and prepare the people for return and restoration.

Memory Verse : Ezekiel 36: 33- 35

‘Thus says the Lord God: “On the day that I cleanse you from all your iniquities, I will also enable you to dwell in the cities, and the ruins shall be rebuilt. The desolate land shall be tilled instead of lying desolate in the sight of all who pass by. So they will say, ‘This land that was desolate has become like the garden of Eden; and the wasted, desolate, and ruined cities are now fortified and inhabited.’

Introduction

Ezekiel = God will strengthen

The idea ‘ They will know I am God’ is repeated many times in this book and God uses judgement on the nations around Jerusalem and restoration for his people to prove the point.

Ezekiel was a prophet during the exilic period. He was taken to Babylon in BC 597, some eleven years before the destruction of Jerusalem. Some 120 years before, the northern kingdom of Israel was captured by the Assyrians. This captivity also happened multiple times.

Israel’s exile in Assyrian

BC 734 – Galilee and north – west part of Israel were captured by Tiglath- Pileser.

BC 721 – Samaria and the rest of Israel were captured by Sargon II.

BC 701 – Two lakh Israelites were taken as prisoners by Sennacherib

Judah's exile in Babylon

BC 606 – Some of the people are carried into exile to Babylon (Daniel included).

BC 597 – More people are taken into exile (Ezekiel is one among them)

BC 586 – Jerusalem is burnt. Total period of exile lasts for 70 years (BC 606 - 536)

Ezekiel – Daniel

Daniel was in Babylon 9 years before Ezekiel arrived. Daniel was prominent by that time (Eze. 14:14, 20; 28:3). Daniel ministered in the palace while Ezekiel ministered among the exiles. They had peaceful and enriching fellowship among themselves.

Ezekiel – Jeremiah

Jeremiah was older to Ezekiel. Ezekiel might have been a disciple of Jeremiah. The message that Ezekiel preached to the exiles was the same as Jeremiah. Their message was about the punishment as the result of sin in Judah.

Ezekiel – Apostle John

The visions of Ezekiel can be seen in the revelations received by the Apostle John.

1. Visions of Cherubims	Eze. Ch.1	Rev. Ch. 4
2. Gog – Magog	Ch. 38	Ch. 20
3. Eating the scrolls	Ch. 3	Ch. 10
4. New Jerusalem	Chs. 40-48	Ch. 21
5. River of Life	Ch. 47	Ch. 22

One of the main themes of this book is “They will know that I am God”. This verse is repeated 62 times in 27 chapters. We can see this in chapters 6 to 39 (Find out the verses from 6:7 – 30:28).

Ezekiel's prophecy pointed out God's providence in the events while in exile. The reason for the exile was the sin of the people. Though their sins destroyed the other nations, God punished them but did not destroy them. In the midst of judgement, God proclaimed that "They will know that I am God". It was to deliver them from idolatry that God sent them to exile in Babylon.

Date of the events in Ezekiel

The destruction of Jerusalem in BC 586, is the main theme of this book. The prophet Ezekiel must have begun his ministry 6 years before the destruction of the city of Jerusalem. And he might have been in ministry for 16 years after the destruction of Jerusalem. A total of 22 years. He prophesied about the fall, which will surely happen. When we read chapters 1 to 24 we see the prophecy. In chapters 25 to 32, he prophesies about the destruction of the neighbouring nations and in chapters 33 to 48, he prophesies about the glorious restoration of Judah.

Many of his prophecies are mentioned by date. The dates mentioned are in relation to the reign of Jehoiakim and the exile. Ezekiel began his ministry at the age of 30, during the reign of Jehoiakim and as a result of the happenings of the time. Since Ezekiel was a priest, he is set to start his priestly duties at the age of 30 (Num. 4:3). Both John, the Baptist and our Lord Jesus Christ – started this ministry at the age of 30. After a struggle which lasts 30 years, Babylon took supremacy over Assyria. Nabopolassar (Nebuchadnezzar's father) was the one who took control of Babylon from Assyria in BC 625. (Thus there are many thoughts on the subject of 30 year).

Date of the visions of Ezekiel

Chapter	Holy Calendar	BC
1. Ch. 1:2	5 th year 4 th month (Tammuz)	Day 5, 592
2. Ch. 8:2	6 th year 6 th month (Elul)	Day 5, 591
3. Ch. 20:1	7 th year 5 th month (Av/Ab)	10 th day 590
4. Ch. 24:1	9 th year 10 th month (Tevet)	10 th day 587

Attack on Jerusalem

- | | | | |
|-----|------------------------------|--|--------------------------|
| 5. | Ch. 24:2 | 9 th year 10 th month (Tevet) | 10 th day 587 |
| 6. | Ch. 26:1 (Tyre) | 11 th year 5 th month (Av/Ab) | 1 st day 586 |
| 7. | Ch. 29:1 (Egypt) | 10 th year 10 th month (Tevet) | 12 th day 586 |
| 8. | Ch. 29:17 (Babylon) | 27 th year 1 st month (Abib) | 1 st day 570 |
| 9. | Ch. 30:20
(Egypt Pharaoh) | 11 th year 1 st month (Abib) | 7 th day 586 |
| 10. | Ch. 32:1
(Egypt Pharaoh) | 12 th year 12 th month (Adar) | 1 st day 584 |

Fall of Jerusalem

- | | | | |
|-----|--|--|--------------------------|
| 11. | Ch. 32:1
(Egypt Pharaoh) | 12 th year 12 th month (Adar) | 1 st day 584 |
| 12. | Ch. 32:17
(Egypt nation) | 12 th year 12 th month (Adar) | 15 th day 584 |
| 13. | Ch. 33:21
(Jerusalem) | 12 th year 10 th month (Tevet) | 5 th day 584 |
| 14. | Ch. 40:1
(Jerusalem after
Destruction) | 25 th year 1 st month (Abib) | 10 th day 572 |

Ezekiel was very particular in listing the dates of his prophecy. All events are clearly dated. Each vision has its effect till the next.

Ezekiel – Settlement – Date

Ezekiel was led into exile along with Jehoiachin in BC 597 (33:21; 40:1). He was married (24:13-18), had a house (8:1) and lived on the banks of the River Chebar.

River Chebar was a canal made to connect River Euphrates to Babylon for trading purposes. It was made by Nebuchadnezzar and is called the Grand Canal (1:1; 3:15,23). It was constructed through the city of Nippur, which was 50 miles southeast of Babylon. Another name is Calneh. This was one of the cities made by Nimrod (Gen. 10:10). This

is where Ezekiel settled while in exile. The proper place seems to be ‘Tel – Abib’ (3:15-24). This is near Nippur. There is a small village in the outskirts of the city called Kilfil. This village is believed to be the place of Noah and is known in his name (14:14, 20). The place ‘ Eridu’ said to be part of the Garden of Eden is here (28:13; 31:8,9,18;36:25).

It is to be noted that throughout his prophecy, he addresses himself as ‘Son of Man’. We can see it 90 times in the book. Daniel uses this name ‘ Son of Man’ for the Messiah. Our Lord Jesus Christ used it for himself.

Visions, parables, and visuals were all part of Ezekiel’s prophecy. In the context of persecution, he went around as if mute for sometime (3:26; 24:27; 38:22). As a sign, he lay on his left side for a year (4:5), ate low cost food(4:10,12,15), and his beloved wife died (24:16-18). All these he used to convey his messages.

Ezekiel is the son of Buzi, the priest (1:3). He was taken to Babylon during the time of Jehoiachin, eleven years before the destruction of Jerusalem (2 Kings 24:12-15). He received his first vision on the banks of the river Chebar (Canal). He was prominent among the exiles (8:1; 11:25; 14:1; 20:1). His courage and strength was very outstanding. He was always striving for the blessings and prosperity of his people. Ezekiel was not overly concerned about the people of other nations. He was an ordinary Jewish priest. The secret of his ministry was hidden in his knowledge of Godly calling. The last message with dates provided is found in 29:17 (BC 570). His prophecies motivated the exiles. Though they are dry bones, yet God will join them together and send the breath of life and make them a mighty army, giving them a glorious hope for the future (37:1). “Then they will know that I am God” (8:7).

Hebrew name ‘Yehezkel’ (God will strengthen – 3:8,9), Greek name ‘Ezekiel’; Latin name ‘Ezechiel’. The English is similar to Greek and Latin.

Author

It is mentioned in the beginning, that the author is Ezekiel, Son of Buzi. Like Jeremiah, Ezekiel also, though a priest, received a calling for a prophetic ministry. In his ministry, a priestly outlook is evident. Some of the common topics include the temple, priesthood, sacrifice and

Shekinah (glory). He had numerous visions to substantiate God's will. His writings were literary classics. We can see masculine pronouns all through out the writings (1:3; 24:24). His lifetime style, uniformity of language, chronological arrangement and structured balance of his writings is to be greatly appreciated. His repetition of certain phrases is very touching – (1) They will know that I am God; (2) Address of the Son of Man'; (3) The hand of God came upon me; (4) The Glory of God.

Date of Writing – B.C. 6th Century

Nebuchadnezzar attacked Jerusalem three times. In the first attack (BC 605), he defeated Jehoiakim and took Daniel and his friends into exile. In the second attack (BC 597), he defeated Jehoiachin and took Jehoiachin, Ezekiel and others into exile. During the third attack (BC 586), he destroyed Jerusalem. Ezekiel was exiled at the age of 25 and received his calling to the prophetic ministry at the age of 30 (1:1-3). He served for 22 years (1:3; 29:17). This book is believed to be completed in BC 565.

Birth of Ezekiel – BC 622

Babylonian Exile – BC 597

First Prophetic Vision – BC 592

Completion of Writing – BC 565

Ezekiel – Christ

In Eze. 17:22-24, we read of a tall cedar tree and a tender shoot that are cut off. It is taken to a tall mountain and planted there. It grows into a large tree and in its shadow all the birds and animals find rest. This is a shadow of Christ.

Isaiah denotes Christ as a branch (Isa. 11:1; Jer. 23:5; 33:15; Zech. 3:8; 6:12)

Messiah as sovereign ruler – Eze. 21:26,27

True Shepherd – Redeemer – One who searches (34:11- 31)

Main Theme

Future of Israel – Restoration – Comfort to the exiles – Strengthening the exile (37:11, 15-24)

Summary of Ezekiel

Ezekiel ministered to the exiles in Babylon. Both Ezekiel and Jeremiah were similar in their ministry. While Jeremiah prophesied to the people who failed to repent of their sins, Ezekiel prophesied to the people in exile about the restoration of Jerusalem. In the midst of fear and judgement, Ezekiel gave the message of hope and comfort and pointed out to them the future glory and reminded the people of God – “They will know that I am God”.

Ezekiel’s Prophecy can be divided into four parts:

- | | |
|--------------------------|------------|
| 1. Ezekiel is appointed | Chs. 1-3 |
| 2. Judgement on Judah | Chs. 4- 24 |
| 3. Judgement on Nations | Chs. 25-32 |
| 4. Restoration of Israel | Chs. 33-48 |

1. Ezekiel’s Appointment – Chs. 1-3

God gave Ezekiel the vision of His glory. Along with that he was appointed as a prophet.

God appointed Moses – Ex. 3:1-16

God appointed Isaiah – Isa. 6:1-10

God appointed Daniel – Daniel 10:5-14

God appointed John – Rev. 1:12-19

In the same way, God appointed Ezekiel and gave him the ability and the responsibility to fulfill the task.

2. Judgement on Judah – Chs. 4-24

When the people chosen by God commit sin, God give them the message by judgement.

The prophet gave the message and the signs – Chs. 4-7

Judah punished – Chs. 8-11

The former sins of Judah – Judgement – understanding of God’s will, loss of God’s glory, priests and kings killed – the glory departs east to Mt. Olive and disappears – and the punishment coming on Judah due to sin – enacted through messages and visions. The prophets of Judah were liars and their elders idol worshippers. They were branches of vine without fruit and a adulterous wife. And so they were sent to Babylon. Egypt did not help them. People had to bear their own sin. The sin of theirforefathers were also accounted to them. Judah is punished for unfaithfulness. Yet God promised a future restoration (12 – 24).

3. Judgement on Nations – Chs. 25-32

Judah’s neighbours pushed them towards destruction. God will judge those nations. They were also destroyed by Babylon. God sent judgement on all the neighbouring nations–(1) Ammon, (2) Moab, (3)Edom, (4) Philistia, (5) Tyre, (6) Sidon (25-28).

More chapters were used to describe the judgement on Tyre. The king of Tyre represents Satan (28:11-24). His strength was destroyed (29-32) and so ended its glory (29:15).

4. Restoration of Israel – Chs. 33-48

The message of restoration is given to Judah after the fall of Jerusalem. The prophets sends out the message of comfort. Just as God declared judgement for sins, in the same way, he proclaimed blessings and restoration. Ezekiel proclaims that God will bring back the exiles. Just as he prophesied, Jerusalem was destroyed. The false prophets and shepherds and evil leaders were all removed. In the future, the true shepherd will lead his flock. God will breathe the breath of life on the valley of dry bones. Gog will come from the north to destroy them but God will stand with Israel and so Gog will be destroyed. 14 years after the fall of Jerusalem, he gets a vision of the fallen city and the temple (40 -48). The prophet sees the outer and inner courts of the temple. The glory of God descends once again asalso a new kingdom and a new city (New heavens and new earth).

This book has 48 chapters and 1279 verses.

Questions

1. “They will know that I am God.” Elaborate on the importance of this statement in the book of Ezekiel.
2. Make a chart on the historical events including exile of Israel – Judah.
3. What similarity do the visions that Ezekiel had, have with Daniel, Jeremiah and John?
4. Write on the date of the events in Ezekiel.
5. Prepare a chart on the Date of the Visions.
6. Write a paragraph on Ezekiel’s place of settlement in Babylon. What is its importance?
7. Ezekiel’s prophecy is symbolic. Elaborate.
8. Write a paragraph on Ezekiel’s ministry and events.
9. Discuss Christ symbolism in Ezekiel.
10. Write a summary on the book of Ezekiel.
11. Write on the variants of the name of Ezekiel.

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LESSON 5

Daniel

Objective : To understand the life of Daniel, who held a very high official position, in a foreign country, in a multicultural context, lived a godly life and served the people.

Memory Verse :

Dan. 2:20 – 22: Daniel answered and said: “Blessed be the name of God forever and ever, For wisdom and might are His. And He changes the times and the seasons; He removes kings and raises up kings; He gives wisdom to the wise And knowledge to those who have understanding. He reveals deep and secret things; He knows what is in the darkness, And light dwells with Him.

Daniel 2:24: Therefore Daniel went to Arioch, whom the king had appointed to destroy the wise men of Babylon. He went and said thus to him: “Do not destroy the wise men of Babylon; take me before the king, and I will tell the king the interpretation.”

Introduction

Daniel – God, my Judge

Daniel is prominent as a royalty, a prophet and as a man of God. In his youth, he was taken into exile in Babylon. He lived in Babylon and served the Babylonian and Persian kings. In the first attack of Nebuchadnezzar, during the reign of Jehoiakim Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah are taken captive and exiled to Babylon. They were given special training and entered the king's service. Daniel was around 16 years. Slowly, he reached the highest position. As a prophet, he conveyed the message of the future, where both Jews and Gentiles together enjoy the blessings of the kingdom of God. Daniel's prophetic ministry started during the reign of Nebuchadnezzar and continued through the reign of Darius, king of the Medes and extended to the time of Cyrus, King of Persia, a total span of 70 years. In his visions, that God gave him, we see symbolism of trees, animals, wild animals, statues. Daniel was a member of royalty.

The book of Daniel is a book of Kings and nations. The book includes crowns and empires, various historical events, prophetic truths, indicators of end time happenings and prophecies of the kingdom of God, judgements and eternity.

City of Babylon

Daniel lived and ministered in the city of Babylon, one of the ancient wonders. Babylon is called “the cradle of civilization”. This city is near the Garden of Eden and was situated around the tower of Babel.

The beautiful city of Babylon was the capital city of Babylon, Assyria and Persian empires. Alexander, the Great, also stayed there for sometime. Before the Christian era, it was a world famous city. The city

reached its zenith (peak) of glory during the reign of Nebuchadnezzar, during the time of Daniel. Nebuchadnezzar spend a large part of his reign in building and beautifying the city.

The city of Babylon was a 15 mile square shaped city and had a circumference of 60 miles. The walls were massive. The foundations of the walls were 35 feet deep, with a height of 300 feet and width of 30 feet. The bricks used were 1 foot in length, 1 foot in breadth and 4 inches in height. A quarter mile away from the walls, wide and deep moats were made. There were 250 bulwarks on top of the walls. Solders were on guard on the walls day and night. The city had 100 bronze gates. The river Euphrates flowed through the city. The banks of the river were dyked with walls. There were 25 bronze gates opening to the river and ferries were also used. There was a bridge, connecting the two parts of the cities, which was half a mile long and 30 feet wide. To get to this bridge, a person had to climb smaller movable bridges on either side. These movable bridges were laid aside during the night. There was also a tunnel, 15 feet wide and 12 feet tall, under the river, connecting the two parts.

There was a large temple for Baal, near the city tower. There was a large open platform, of which there was no equal during the time. There was a golden statue of Baal. It was placed on a golden table. The total weight of it was 50,000 sovereigns (500 kg gold). Moreover there were also golden lions, golden idols were very present in the city at various locations, making it a 'Golden city'. This religious city had 53 other temples and also 180 Ashtaroth altars. This city on a plateau extended from the tower of Babel to the place of Nebuchadnezzar golden statue (Dan. 3:1). The royal palace was also very beautiful. The walls of the king's room was 20 feet thick. There were three walls around the palace. It is near impossible to get into the palace. Each wall was 50 feet thick. There were gaps between the walls, and large and small chunks of rock were used to fill in these space.

The famous 'hanging gardens' were made by Nebuchadnezzar to please his queen. Plants and trees were grown in them. Water was pumped from the river and it reached all corners of the garden through small dug out stream beds. There were also spacious rooms and entertainment palaces too. Using special architectural skills, it was hung in the sky.

All of these have been destroyed due to external attacks and have now been turned into a dunghill. The bricks have been salvaged and used in modern times in the construction of canals in Bagdad. As prophesied, the city has become refuse.

The book of Daniel is known in the prophet's name itself both in Hebrew and Greek bibles, as also in Latin and English.

Author

There is indication in the book itself that Daniel is the author (7:1-25; 8:2; 9:2; 10:12; 14:4,5). We see a usage of 'Daniel, a man greatly beloved' a direct address from God (Matt. 24:13 – 15). Christians and Jews alike credit Daniel as the author of this book. Some of the verses, we find in Aramaic – Chaldean language (2:4-7:28). The rest were written in Hebrew. The Hebrew is similar to that of the exilic Jews. Daniel prophesied about the time of the Gentiles, the tribulation and the rule of the Messiah. When the rulers in the world become corrupt and the rule becomes evil, then God will establish his righteous rule on the earth.

Date – Historicity

Babylon defeated Assyria in BC 626. They also captured Nineveh, the capital city. In BC 612, with the defeat of Egypt at the hands of the Babylonians, they became rulers of Mid – East. Nebuchadnezzar also attacked and conquered Jerusalem and took captives of the people. Daniel was one among them. Even when Babylon fell to the Medes and Persians in BC 539, Daniel continued as a ruler and prophet. His prophetic ministry was used for the gentile nations too. He continued his ministry during the reigns of Nebuchadnezzar, Belshazzar, Darius and Cyrus.

During the first year of Cyrus, the first group of exiles returned to Jerusalem, under the leadership of Zerubbabel. Daniel lived till the third year of the reign of Cyrus (BC 536 – 10:1). Daniel also predicted that the Persian empire will survive till the time of Alexander, the Great (11:2,3). The Persian empire extended till India. Later the Romans defeated the Greeks and took supremacy. Later it will give way to democracy paving the way for a Messianic rule as prophesied by Daniel.

Some of the biblical scholars are of the opinion that the book of Daniel was written later in the name of Daniel, after the fulfilment of

some of the prophecies. The reason being, the major portion of the messages in chapter two had been fulfilled accurately. Some are of the opinion that it had been written to encourage the people in exile and give them hope. But for a true believer, these opinions have no value.

The Aramaic language used in chapters 2 to 7 are thought by some to be a newer version of that language. The argument that the Persian language that Daniel was a later version is false. Archaeology proves that the language in the book of Daniel was used during the reign of Cyrus. It is to be noted that Greek, Assyrian, and Persian languages were spoken in the court of the king and therefore, Greek words were very prevalent at the time of Daniel. These prove that Daniel was the author of this book.

Since Daniel was very careful to mention the date of the events, the argument that the book of Daniel was written after the events happened does not hold value. Therefore, all arguments against the authorship of Daniel is negated.

Christ in Daniel

The stone that crushes the kingdoms of the world is Christ (2:34, 35, 44, 45). The Son of Man takes authority and that Son of Man is the Christ (7:13,14).

The Messiah is slain. This is Christ's sacrificial death (Ch. 9). The resurrected Messiah is described (10:5-9, Rev. 1:12-16). The 70-week period is God's rule for the Jews and inspires biblical students everywhere (9:24-27). With the coming of Jesus, the 69 weeks are done. The last week (70th week) will happen with the coming of Christ in midair and the rapture of the church.

Main theme – God's will for Israel

God rules over the nations. God appoints rulers of the world (4:25) and provides hope to the faithful by reminders of the coming Messiah and restoration to the people of Israel.

The Book of Daniel – Summary

The book of Daniel is considered the revelation of the Old Testament. It contains a comprehensive prophetic future.

After writing a good introduction (Ch. 1) in Hebrew, chapters 2-7 is written in Aramaic. Chapters 8-12 gives an outline of the future of the Gentile nations. These prophetic truths have importance to the church, just as it did for the Jews. Babylon, Persia, Greece, and Rome conquered and ruled the Jews, but, in the end, Messiah will deliver and rule them.

This book can be divided into 3 parts:

1. Daniel's history (Ch. 1) – Introduction
2. The future of the nations (Ch. 2-7)– prophecy
3. Future of Israel (Ch. 8-12) – prophecy

Daniel's history (Introduction)

The prophet gives an introduction in which he brings out his background along with the background of the book. Daniel and his friends are taken to the palace of Nebuchadnezzar for training. The king gave them Babylonian names and food. But Daniel and his friends trusted God, and God gave them better health, knowledge, and wisdom than that of the other young men.

Future of the Nations (prophecy)

Daniel interpreted the king's vision of the golden statue (Ch. 2), receiving the knowledge of the four empires that was to come and the Messiah, whose kingdom will be forever.

The king raised up a golden statue to worship (Ch. 3). As a result of disobeying the law, Daniel's three friends were thrown into a furnace. God descended into the furnace and delivered them. The interpretation of the king's dream about the cut-down tree revealed how the king will be humbled. Chapter 5 speaks about the feast of Belshazzar and the end of the Babylonian rule. Chapter 6 speaks of the deliverance of Daniel from the lion's den. Chapter 7 deals with Daniel's vision of the four beasts, denoting Babylonian empire, the Median-Persian empire, the Greek empire, and the Roman empire. The chapter ends with God establishing his invincible kingdom.

Future of Israel (prophecy)

The struggle between the ram and the goat (Ch. 8) defines the struggle between the Mede-Persian and the Greek empires. The one horn of the goat (the Greek empire) is Alexander the Great. The smaller horn is Antiochus Epiphanes. In chapter 9, we find the repentant prayer of Daniel. Afterwards, the vision of the 70 weeks is received. It also reveals the death of the Messiah and God's plan of redemption. In chapters 10 and 11, we find Israel's future in prophecy. Chapter 11 gives a picture of Greece and Persia. Chapter 12 depicts the story of the war between Ptolemy of Egypt and Seleucus of Syria, in which Antiochus Epiphanes is captured, which results in deliverance to Israel.

This book has 12 chapters and 357 verses.

Questions:

1. Write a short history on the life of Daniel.
2. How did the city of Babylon become famous?
3. Name the language used in the book of Daniel. Give reasons.
4. Write a paragraph on the date and historicity of Daniel
5. Prove that the book of Daniel was written before the events took place?
6. Bring out Christ in the book of Daniel.
7. Write a summary on the book of Daniel
8. How does the book of Daniel talk about the time of the Gentiles? Which nations are mentioned in the book of Daniel?
9. Compare the vision of the golden statue and the vision of the four beasts.

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LESSON 6

Hosea

Objective : To reveal the redeeming love of God. Even if a person commits sin and transgression, there is deliverance and restoration for those who turn back to God

Memory Verse :

Hosea 4:1 - Hear the word of the Lord, You children of Israel, For the Lord brings a charge against the inhabitants of the land: “There is no truth or mercy Or knowledge of God in the land.

Hosea 11:7-9 - My people are bent on backsliding from Me. Though they call to the Most High, None at all exalt Him. “How can I give you up, Ephraim? How can I hand you over, Israel? How can I make you like Admah? How can I set you like Zeboiim? My heart churns within Me; My sympathy is stirred. I will not execute the fierceness of My anger; I will not again destroy Ephraim. For I am God, and not man, The Holy One in your midst; And I will not come with terror.

Introduction

Israel is sidelined due to unfaithfulness. God sent many gentile nations to punish them. Hosea was a prophet of the northern kingdom of Israel. (The northern kingdom was Israel and the largest tribe was Ephraim. Therefore, the nation was addressed as ‘Israel’ and ‘Ephraim’). When the prophet talks about the king, he addresses them as ‘our king’ (7:5). The focus of this prophecy is Israel, the northern kingdom. Yet, there are messages to Judah as well. Hosea ministered towards the end of the kingdom of Israel, approximately 60 years.

Hosea started his ministry during the time of Jeroboam II. It was a period of prosperity, but the people were spiritually and morally corrupt. Hosea was a contemporary of Amos, who was older, and Isaiah and

Micah, who were both younger. The prophet Jonah may have been alive when Hosea was young.

During Hosea's ministry, we have Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah as kings of Judah and Jeroboam II, Zechariah, Shallum, Menachem, Pekahiah, Pekah, and Hoshea as kings of Israel. His main part of the ministry was during the reign of Jeroboam II, king of Israel, and Hezekiah, king of Judah. He lived around B.C. 790-697 (93 years). The correct period of his ministry is hard to determine. It may be that he ministered from B.C. 748-690.

Two hundred years before Hosea, the kingdom was divided into two – the northern kingdom of Israel (10 tribes) and the southern kingdom of Judah (2 tribes). The kingdom of Israel had its capital as Samaria. Elijah, Elisha, Jonah, and Amos were prophets sent by God to exhort this nation to turn back to God. Later, God sent Hosea, son of Beeri. He preached faithfully to his people, yet they did not repent. He used Aramaic to preach since they were more into the Aramaic language and culture. We see their many practices in the book (5:1; 6:8-9; 12:12). Hosea used the pronoun 'our' to denote anything Israelite. For example, "our land" and "our king".

Hosea narrates his heart-breaking family story to the nation of Israel, who had forsaken God and had gone after lovers. Some considered this prophecy as a story similar to the condition of Israel. Under the direction of God, Hosea marries Gomer, daughter of Diblaim. She was a prostitute. He had two sons, Jezreel (God sows – disperses; Ch. 1:4,5), and Lo-Ammi (Not my people – 1:9). They had a daughter named Lo-ruhamah (No compassion – 1:16). Gomer and her children are symbolic of Israel ("for the nation have committed whoredom and departed from God" Hosea 1:2). Gomer, who turned unfaithful to Hosea, was sold as a slave (Ch. 1 and 2). Hosea goes in search of Gomer, pays her price, and redeems her back (Ch.3). This is an example of God loving and delivering the people of Israel. This book points to a futuristic hope of a people who have rejected God and Christ. The prophet points to the eternal love of God. God looks gravely on the sin of the people (Romans 11:1-24). There is punishment for sin. God punishes – not to destroy – but for mankind to turn back and repent. This is the message that Hosea conveys to us.

The names 'Hosea', 'Joshua', and 'Yeshua' are variants of the same name. It means 'the Lord saves' or 'Yahweh is salvation'.

In English, the prophet's name is 'Hosea'. Similarly, the last king of Israel is named Hoshea. Note the difference in spelling. In Greek, it is known as 'Hosee' and in Latin, it is known as 'Hoseas'. Many scholars opine that Hosea wrote this book (1:1). He was a resident of the northern kingdom of Israel. There are no other references in any other books of the Old Testament concerning the author or the book. Hosea's message gives assurance of God's love and mercy. God loves sinners but hates the sin. He wants all sinners to repent.

Date of Writing

This book is believed to have been written during the early reign of Hezekiah, who ruled between B.C. 755 and B.C. 710. Therefore, the book must have been written in the 8th century.

Historicity

Hosea ministered a little more than half a century. He prophesied before and after the fall of Samaria.

Christ in Hosea

The reference in Matthew 2:15 is quoted from Hosea 11:1. The subject is the return of Jesus from Egypt, where his parents fled due to the fear for the child's safety.

This verse (11:1) depicts Israel's return from Egypt and the rebuilding of the nation. This also symbolizes Christ. Both Israel and Christ resided in Egypt. Even today, God delivers people from slavery.

The love Hosea had shown to his wife who was a prostitute and a slave points to the love of God and the deliverance through Christ from sin.

Main Theme

The love of God which loves the sinner and the impure and delivers and restores them to himself.

The Book of Hosea – Summary

This book presents God's love for Israel. The context of the message is found in chapters 1-3.

Gomer's prostitution (Ch.1) - Israel's sin (Ch. 4-7)

Gomer's rejection (Ch. 2) - Israel's judgement (Ch. 8-10)

Gomer's redemption (Ch. 3) - Israel's restoration (Ch. 11-14)

This book is very different from other prophetic writings because Hosea's personal story is the foundation of the writing.

The relationship between Gomer and her husband points to the faithfulness, love, patience, and judgement of God.

We are able to see God's holiness, Israel's impurity, God's justice, Israel's injustice, God's love, Israel's rebellion, God's unconditional love, Israel's countless sins, and God's patience towards Israel, waiting for their repentance (11:1).

Hosea gives 150 reminders to Israel about their sin. More than half the reminders were against idol worship. There were no God-fearing kings in Israel. Therefore, severe punishments followed. Yet God desired his people to turn back to Him.

Just as Jeremiah warned the people of Judah to turn back before the impending disaster, Hosea reminds the people of Israel to return to God before disaster strikes. A figurative explanation of Israel as wife and Yahweh as a husband – Yahweh's faithfulness and love is described here.

Just as Hosea married Gomer, Yahweh married Israel. Gomer went after lovers, Israel similarly going after other gods.

Israel's spiritual adultery is equivalent to gomer's physical adultery. This book can be divided into 2 parts, as follows:

1. An adulterous wife and a faithful husband (Ch. 1-3)
2. An adulterous nation and a faithful God (Ch. 4-14)

An adulterous wife and faithful husband (1-3)

Hosea marries Gomer, a prostitute, and has 3 children. This symbolizes Israel. God takes Israel, who went after other gods, for Himself. But Gomer searched for other lovers and rejected Hosea. Similarly, Israel rejected God and went after idols. Hosea went in search of Gomer and bought her back for himself the slave market. God is Israel's Redeemer and the faithful husband.

An adulterous nation and a faithful God (4-14)

We see God's pain through the pain that Hosea undergoes. This book is yet another attempt on God's part to bring back a backsliding nation. Israel broke and rejected God's law. God punishes the sin yet desires that the people would turn back, so God can deliver and heal them (7:13-14). In chapters 8,9 and 10, we see God gives a narration of their sins. He reminds them that they sow the wind and reap a whirlwind (8:6-7).

God is holy – chapters 4-7

God is righteous – chapters 8-10

God's people – filled with God's mercy

God's punishment is also with love. In the end, he will save and restore his vineyard. (11:8; 14:4)

Hosea has 14 chapters with 197 verses.

Questions

1. Prove that Hosea was a resident of the northern kingdom of Israel
2. List the names of the kings that ruled Israel and Judah
3. How can we say that Hosea's family story is the basis of this book?
4. Bring out the variants in the name 'Hosea'.
5. Elaborate on the date and historicity of this book.
6. Write about Christ in Hosea
7. What comparison can we give between chapters 1-3 and the rest of the book?
8. Bring out the summary of the book of Hosea.

LESSON 7

Joel

Objective : A study of the age of the gospel, infilling of the Holy Spirit, the arrival of the day of the Lord, and judgment based in the book.

Memory Verse :

Joel 2:11 - The Lord gives voice before His army, For His camp is very great; For strong is the One who executes His word. For the day of the Lord is great and very terrible; Who can endure it?

Joel 2:28, 29 - "And it shall come to pass afterward That I will pour out My Spirit on all flesh; Your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, Your old men shall dream dreams, Your young men shall see visions. And also on My menservants and on My maidservants I will pour out My Spirit in those days.

Introduction

Joel means ‘Yahweh is God’

Like the book of Zephaniah, this book bases its messages on the judgement (the plague of locusts) and deliverance, the dawn of the gospels, and the pouring out of the Holy Spirit. Like the book of revelation, Joel speaks of the harvest of the Gentiles (3:13,14; Rev. 14:15,16). The prophet Joel is thought to be one of the earliest writing prophets of Judah. There is no mention of any kings in this book. This book begins with the plague of locusts and the famine that follows. The prophet urges the people to turn to God for deliverance. “Those who repent will have deliverance and blessings will be showered upon them” (2:18-19; 2:23-25). The plague can be real or figurative. Joel reaffirms the fact that if the judgement passes away, the wrath of God has been appeased and He will pour out his Spirit on the people and prosperity

will also be in the land. Joel is the son of Pethuel (encouraged by God) and nothing more is known.

Joel was a resident of the southern kingdom of Judah and was also a priest. This prophecy gives assurance and a warning on the time of the Gentiles, blessings of the Kingdom of God, Battle of Armageddon, rejuvenation of Israel as a nation, the second coming of Christ, and the millennial rule.

Time of the Gentiles,

Blessings of the Kingdom of God – 2:28; Luke 21:14; Rev. 16:14

Israel is conquered,

Beast – false prophet – 2:1-10; Rev. 16:13-14

The promise of deliverance for Israel – 2:18-27

Pouring out of the Holy Spirit – 2:28-32

The era of the church,

The second coming of Christ – 2:30-32; Acts 25:15-18

The judgement on the enemies – 3:1-16

Millennial rule – 3:17-21; Zech. 14:1-25

The Hebrew name for this book is Yoel. The meaning of Joel is ‘Yahweh is God’. The message of the book is also the same. God’s sovereignty over the universe, over nature and over the people. The control of everything is in His hands. The Greek term is ‘Jeol’ and the Latin term is ‘Joel’.

Author

There are many individuals named ‘Joel’ in the bible. Yet only one prophet is famous by that name. Since Joel was close to the functioning of the temple services, he might have been a priest. The topics such as the temple of God, the priest, services, fasting, trumpets, altar, repentance, blessing, salvation, saviour, lament, Jerusalem, the voice of God, the holy mountain of Zion (Joel 1:9,13,16; 2:15-17,23,32; 3:1,5,6, 16,17, 20,21) all point to a resident near Jerusalem and very much connected to the services in the temple. Joel is the writer (1:1) and he was in the kingdom of Judah.

Date

B.C. 9th or 8th century.

There is no indication of the period of writing. Joel may have lived during the time of king Josiah in B.C. 730. He is believed to be earlier than many of the writing prophets. It is written in the ancient Hebrew literary style. Amos may have been inspired by Joel (3:16 cf Amos 1:2; Joel 3:18 cf Amos 9:13). Joel was before Amos, who lived in the 8th century (B.C.). It may be the reformation brought about by Josiah which put a stop to idol-worship in Judah at least for some time and that may be the reason for Joel to be silent on the subject. Josiah lived during the 9th century (B.C.).

Historicity

It is not easy to guess the historicity of the book. Some say that the book was written after the exile. Reasons being as follows:

1. There is no reference about the northern kingdom of Israel. It may have been destroyed (after 722 B.C.).
2. There is a reference to the priestly ministry and not of any kings. After the exile, there were priests but no kings.
3. There is no mention of Assyria, Syria, or Babylon. All of these empires already came to an end.
4. If the verse 3:2 points to the Babylonian exile, we can say with certainty that it was written after the exile.
5. Verse 3:6 denotes the Greek empire. Since the Greeks were after the Babylonian and Persian empires, there is a solid argument of post-exilic writing.

Many scholars do not accept these arguments. They opine that it was written in the 9th or 8th century (B.C.). Reasons as follows:

1. The prophecy was given to the southern kingdom of Judah and is the reason for not mentioning Israel.
2. Many of the pre-exilic prophets, such as Obadiah, Jonah, Nahum, and Habakkuk do not mention the name of kings. At the time of

Joel, Josiah was the king regent until he became of age. Jehoiada the priest served as the regent (Queen Athaliah killed all the princes except the hidden Josiah).

3. The reason for not mentioning Assyria or Babylon in the 9th century being the fact that they were not prominent. The enemies of Judah were Phoenix, Philistia, Edom, and Egypt. It is post-exilic that Persia became prominent. The Hebrews had no knowledge of the Greek empire.

Therefore, Joel must have been written in the 8th or 9th century (B.C.).

Christ in Joel

The words of Jesus fulfil the message of Joel, "... if I depart, I will send him (Holy Spirit) unto you." (John 16:7-15; Acts 1:8). On the day of Pentecost, Peter quotes Joel in his message (Acts 2:16-21 and Joel 2:28-32). It is Christ who comes for judgement in the valley of Jehoshaphat (Joel 3:12).

Main Theme

The final salvation of Judah – prophecy of the church era (the great and terrible day of the Lord).

Book of Joel - Summary

The main topic is the coming of the day of the Lord (1:15; 2:1,2,11,31; 3:14,18). The day of the Lord is the day of judgment for those who rejected God. Joel also prophesied the blessings that fall on those who love God. We see sufferings and judgements throughout the book – the plague of the locusts, famine, fire, and wars. We also see blessings and restoration – God's solution to the suffering, hope, blessings, promises of restoration. The day of the Lord is divided into two parts:

- a. The history of the past (1:1-20)
- b. The vision of the future (2:1 to 3:21)

The History of the Past

This is how God judged the land in the past. The locusts destroyed the land, the locusts came up as a cloud, ate up all the vegetation, and left all the wealth destroyed. Severe famines take place, pestilence breaks out, and sorrow spreads everywhere.

The Vision of the Future

The past judgement is also an indication of the terrible judgement yet to come. The land will be an example of the enemies on the day of judgement. There will be terrible events. The consequences of the day of the Lord will be great (2:11). It is blessed to turn to the Lord beforehand (2:12-17). “Therefore, also now, saith the Lord, turn ye even to me with all your heart, and with fasting, and with weeping, and with mourning,” Joel 2:12. God will be gracious to those who turn to Him. But if not, there will be terrible destruction. The judgment yet to come are more terrible than the famine due to the plague of locusts (1:4; 2:25). There will be an outpouring of the Holy Spirit on those who turn to God and judgement to those who reject Him. Then, the final restoration of the Jews will be fulfilled. God controls history for His people (3:17). The people of the nations will know that God dwells in Zion. God will bless the remnants of Judah and will restore them. Judah and Jerusalem will remain from generation to generation (3:20)

The prophetic book of Joel has 3 chapters and 73 verses.

Questions:

1. Summarize the book of Joel
2. How do we know that Joel is a priest?
3. Elaborate on the historicity of the prophecy of Joel?
4. Bring out Christ in this book
5. What is the summary of this book?
6. What are the two parts to the day of the Lord?
7. Where did Joel minister? What was the main theme?

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LESSON 8

Amos

Objective : God appointed Amos, who was a shepherd and a farmer, as a prophet. A Judean goes to Israel and talks about its wickedness, unfaithfulness, and also the restoration of the Davidic line. We also should follow God's guidance.

Memory Verse :

Amos 3:1,2 – Hear this word that the Lord has spoken against you, O children of Israel, against the whole family which I brought up from the land of Egypt, saying: “You only have I known of all the families of the earth; Therefore I will punish you for all your iniquities.”

Amos 8:11-12 – “Behold, the days are coming,” says the Lord God, “That I will send a famine on the land, Not a famine of bread, Nor a thirst for water, But of hearing the words of the Lord. They shall wander from sea to sea, And from north to east; They shall run to and fro, seeking the word of the Lord, But shall not find it.

Introduction

Amos, a resident of the southern kingdom of Judah, goes to Israel and conveys the message of God in the main city of Bethel, 30 years before the fall of Israel.

Amos was born in Tekoa. It is 10 miles south of Jerusalem and 5 miles southeast of Bethlehem. Tekoa is situated on a hilly region, 27000 ft above sea level. John the Baptist was also from this place. Amos was a common man. He was neither a priest, prophet, or a member of the school of prophets. He was a shepherd and a farmer (7:14,15). He used

to collect and take care of the sycamore figs, which is an inferior type of fig. The sycamore tree is also called the fig-mulberry. The book was written 2 years before the earthquake (1:1). Zechariah the prophet speaks about the earthquake 200 years before in the time of Uzziah (Zech. 14:5). When Uzziah was ruling in Judah (B.C. 787-735), Jeroboam II was ruling over Israel (B.C. 790-749). Josephus the historian writes that the earthquake happened sometime after Uzziah became leprous (2 Chron.26:18-21). The earthquake may have happened around B.C. 751.

The time of Jeroboam II was a period of prosperity for the northern kingdom, Israel. The nation extended its borders (2 Kin. 14:23-29). This was a golden time in Israel after Solomon (Amos 6:14). This prosperity led to luxurious living, idol worship, and immorality and destroyed the spiritual strength of the land. As a result, robbery, oppression, immoral life, and murder became daily happenings.

This vision of corruption and wickedness awakened in Amos, the shepherd of Tekoa, a God-given zeal for the law. God anointed him for a prophetic ministry (7:15). He travelled from Judah to Israel, having received the messages of judgement, exile, the rule of the Messiah, and the future. The case of a prophet going from Judah to Israel to deliver a message was very exceptional. The message was for both Israel and Judah. These were for the people's repentance and the fulfillment of the promises of God. When Amos reached Bethel, king Jeroboam and Amaziah the priest stood against him. And so, after he delivered God's message, he returned to Judah. His end is unknown.

It had been only 200 years since the nation of Israel was formed out of the 12 tribes (comprising 10 tribes). They had already turned to 'the calf idol', 'Baal' and other Canaanite gods. Elijah, Elisha and Jonah had preached against it. There was very little change. Hosea and Amos were sent towards the end. The people did not turn back.

Contemporary Prophets of Amos

It is possible that Amos had met Jonah even when he was a young boy. He might have heard about Jonah's journey to Nineveh. He also might have heard about Elijah and Elisha. He ministered in the same place. Joel might have been either earlier or a contemporary. It maybe that Amos is pointing to the same event (the plague of locusts) that Joel

also is dealing with (Amos 2:9). When Amos visited Bethel, Hosea also might have been there, and discussed each other's message. But Amos might have entered the scene only after Hosea had done his ministry. After Amos, Isaiah and Micah might have ministered. But there are also those who say that Amos was an early prophet.

Amos mainly preached in the cities of Samaria, Bethel, and Gilgal. These places have seen God's miracles and they have grievously pained God and so there will be punishment. And so Amos gives the warning note "Get ready to meet your God" (4:12). Amos was very well versed in the scripture.

The meaning of the word 'Amos' is 'Burden', 'borne'. It is thought that Amos is the variant of 'Amaziah' (strengthened by Yahweh).

The Hebrew name is 'Amas'. Latin, Greek, and English, the name given is 'Amos'.

Author

We see the name 'Amos' only in this book. He is not Isaiah's father Amoz. There are quotations from this book in the New Testament, for example, Stephen before Sanhedrin (Acts 7:42-43 – Amos 5:25-27); James in the Jerusalem council (Acts 15:16 – Amos 9:11).

Date

BC 8th century

The time of Uzziah in Judah and Jeroboam II in Israel (BC 751)

Historicity

Amos preached during a time when both Uzziah and Jeroboam II brought prosperity to their kingdoms - Philistia, Ammon and other enemies had been subdued, yet there was large scale immorality and corruption (2:6-8; 3:10; 4:15; 5:10-12; 8:4-6). All the major powers – Assyria, Babylon, Syria, Egypt – were weak. Israel was like the visions that Amos saw of the ripened, yet rotting fruits in the basket which is good to be thrown away.

Christ in Amos

We can see Christ, the one with total authority in 1:1-9:10.

9:11-15 – Christ who restores and establishes a righteous rule

Main theme

If you reject God there will be judgement and exile.

Book of Amos – Summary

Since Israel turned their back to God, in the time of prosperity, Amos reminds them, “Get ready to meet your God”.

This book can be divided into four parts:

1. 8 prophecies (1:1-2:16)
2. 3 messages (3:1-6:14)
3. 5 visions (7:1-9:10)
4. 5 promises (9:11-15)

1. Eight Prophecies (1:1- 2:16)

God called Amos to go to Israel and preach judgement. There are 8 prophecies of judgement in the first 2 chapters, against 8 nations. After the nations is named, he says “three and four sins (transgressions)” (usage) and then comes the judgement using fire which consumes. Judgement is for the 7 nations around Israel and finally Israel itself. There are seven references to ‘fire’ (1:4, 7,10,12,14, 2:2,5). Damascus, Gaza, Tyre, Edom, Ammon, Moab, Judah and Israel are the eight nations.

2. Three Messages (3:1-6:14)

All the three messages begin with ‘Listen to this message’ (3:1; 4:1; 5:1).

- a. Israel’s transgression is great. In chapter 3 the prophet says “Hear the message of judgement”.

- b. The second message can be seen in chapter 4. The message is for the repentance of the people from their wicked rebellious ways. At least five times, we see the phrase “...yet you did not return to me” (4:6,8, 9,10,11).
- c. Chapters 5,6 is the third message. The prophet mentions the transgressions of the people and calls them to repentance. Yet the people rebelled against God. They had to go into exile. They took pride in their wealth and lived selfishly and so destruction came soon after.

3. 5 visions (7:1-9:10)

There are visions of judgement on Israel. God relents of the first two visions of judgement namely locust and fire, after Amos intercedes. The third vision of plumb line, denotes that the way of Israel is in opposition to the plan of God. It is to be noted that Amaziah, the priest confronts Amos and demands that he leaves Bethel for Judah. The fourth vision is of a basket of summer fruits which are over ripe and ready to be thrown in the waste heap – ready for judgement. The fifth vision is of a great judgement that is coming.

4. 5 promises (9:11-15)

Amos does not end his prophecy with the prophecies, messages and visions of judgement. He also gives promises of comfort, hope and restoration. The focal point is the restoration of Davidic line and the rule of Messiah.

- a. God will restore the fallen house of David
- b. God will honour the efforts of his people and give them a good agriculture harvest. God will bless the plowing, sowing, reaping, and also the fruit of the vine.
- c. Israel's exiles will return to their promised land.
- d. They will build strong cities and dwell in them.
- e. They will never be uprooted

The book of Amos has nine chapters and 146 verses.

Questions

1. Narrate the life of Amos.
2. Elaborate on the advantages and disadvantages of the rule of Jeroboam II
3. To which nation did Amos prophecy? Why? What was the result?
4. Write a paragraph on the contemporaries of Amos.
5. Which are the verses given as a warning in the book of Amos?
6. Write a paragraph on 'Christ' in Amos.
7. Write a summary on the prophecies of Amos.
8. How does the life of Amos inspire us?

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LESSON 9

Obadiah

Objective : To understand how God judges the enemies of his people and how he restores them (his people). This prophecy helps us to understand how he deals with the generations of Jacob and Esau.

Memory Verse :

Obadiah 1:10 – “For violence against your brother Jacob, Shame shall cover you, And you shall be cut off forever.

Obadiah 1:21 – Then saviors shall come to Mount Zion To judge the mountains of Esau, And the kingdom shall be the Lord's.

Introduction:

(A. Edom

Edom is a place south of the Dead Sea, around the Seir mountain range. The region is 100 miles in length (south-east) and 20 miles in breadth (east-west). There is much water and the land is lush green. The capital city is 'Sela'. Later the name was changed to 'Petra'. Large rock

formation are part of the region, with beautiful valleys. The way to the cities, is through these rock formations, a good hiding spot for the Edomites, who would use it after each raid on the enemies. It was disastrous for the enemies to attack such natural defenses and overcome Edom. But these Seir inhabitants looked with envy on the kingdom of Judah and Jerusalem (Ps.68:16).

Edomites are the descendants of Esau. The name 'Esau' means 'red'. Esau sold his birthright for 'red lentil soup'. Esau came to reside in the region of the Seir mountains. He defeated the Horrites and removed them from there and lived there. And his descendants are the Edomites.

The Edomites did not allow the Israelites under Moses, through this land, when they came out of Egypt (Num.20:14-21).

Edomites were enemies of Israel from the very beginning. During the times of David and Solomon, they contained themselves to their own region. Jehoshaphat and Jehoram defeated them. But during the time of Ahaz, they revolted. Later Assyria and Babylon defeated them. In the 5th century B.C., the Nabateans utterly destroyed them. Those who escaped fled from their land, to the land of the Idumeans and took on their name. Herod, the great was an Idumean. The enmity was still prevalent even when Herod, the great was ruling over the land. In A.D. 70, when the Roman army under General Titus attacked Judea, the Idumeans opposed them and they were totally destroyed. Edom will be destroyed forever (Obadiah 10) and no survivor will remain of the house of Edom (Obadiah 18).

The story of the conflict between Esau and Jacob is the theme of Obadiah's prophecy and the judgement that fell on the Edomites. The judgement is the result of their wickedness and hatred.

(B). Obadiah

So nothing is known of Obadiah, other than what is mentioned in the book. It is believed that he was a Judean. We don't know about his birthplace or his family. If he was of the royal or of the priestly family, the name of his father would have been mentioned. There are 13 people bearing the name of Obadiah in the Old Testament. Four of them are mentioned below:

1. Obadiah was a prominent figure in the court of Ahab. We read that he hid 100 prophets in caves to save them from the wrath of the royal family (1 Kings 18:3).
2. Obadiah was sent by Jehoshaphat to the cities/towns of Judah to teach the law (2 Chronicles 17:7).
3. Obadiah was put in charge of the renovations of the temple during the time of Josiah (2 Chronicles 34:12)
4. One of the priest during the time of Nehemiah (Nehemiah 10:5)

The meaning of ‘Obadiah’ is ‘Servant of God’ or ‘worshipper of Yahweh’. The form of Obadiah’s name used in Hebrew is ‘Obadyah’; In Greek is ‘Obadios’ and in Latin ‘Abidias’.

Author

Obadiah the prophet, is the writer and nothing is known about him. He lived in Judah and prophesied about the judgement to fall on Edom.

Date and Historicity

There are no references to any kings in the book of Obadiah. The date of the book can be assumed on the basis of certain historical facts. But the attack of Jerusalem and its capture mentioned, further complicates the supposition of date. There are four instances when Jerusalem was attacked and captured.

1. In BC 926, Pharaoh Shishak attacked Jerusalem and damaged the temple. It was during the reign of Rehoboam.

Edom was a vassal state of Judah and so the possibility of this attack as referred to by Obadiah is slim. Moreover it does not stand with the context 10-14. During the time of Obadiah, Edom was independent of Judah.

2. During the reign of Jehoram (848-841), the Philistines and the Arabs had captured Jerusalem (2 Chronicles 21:16,17). At this time, Edom rebelled against Judah and set up their own king (2 Kings 3:20-22 ; 2 Chronicle 21:8-20). This happening relates to the one mentioned by Obadiah.

3. In BC 790, Jehoahaz, the king of Israel attacked and captured Judah (2 Kings 14; 2 Chronicles 25). But Obadiah had referred to the conquerors as ‘foreigners’. It was Israel and the prophet would not have referred to them as ‘foreigners’.
4. In BC 586, Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, attacked and destroyed Jerusalem (2 Kings 24,25)

Of the four incidents, the second and the fourth agreed with verses 10-14. Among the two, the second incident fits the circumstances. The reason being, in the second incident the whole city is not destroyed. During the time of Nebuchadnezzar, everything is destroyed and there is no reference of casting lots taking place among the Babylonians and we cannot point to the plague of locusts in Jerusalem (v.11). The Babylonian attack on Jerusalem took place in BC 586 and led to a total and complete destruction. Prophet Obadiah must have been referring to the incident of 848 to 841 BC- the attack of the Philistine and Arabs. If so, Obadiah was contemporary of Elisha and one of the earliest writing prophet. We can presume that Obadiah was a contemporary of Joel also.

Christ in Obadiah

Christ is the judge of the nations (vs. 15,16). – As the Saviour of Israel (vs 17-20) – As the King (verse 21).

Main Theme

Judgement on Edom – Restoration of Israel.

Obadiah – Summary

There is only 21 verses in this book. Yet there is a strong message of judgement in the book. Edom will never return as a nation. The last verdict from the court of God – total destruction of Edom.

The Book can be divided into two:

1. Destruction of Edom (1-18)
2. Restoration of Israel (19-21)

Destruction of Edom (1-18)

The destruction of Edom has been declared and there is no escape and this happened due to their pride. Their place of refuge is the Seir mountain. The entrance to Edom was very narrow and full of caves. It is difficult for the enemies to get in. Yet nothing is too difficult for God, and whom nobody can stop Him (10-14). The greatest transgression of the people of Edom was the help they extended to the enemies of Israel. And they rejoiced at the fate of Israel. Even when they were part of Israel (vassal-state), they helped the enemies. And so God decided to judge them. Israel will be a fire and the house of Edom will be a stubble (v.13).

Restoration of Israel

The help of God is the hope of Israel. They will not only be restored but will possess the land of the Edomites and the Philistines.

Questions:

1. What is the lesson that the conflict between Jacob & Esau teaches us?
2. Write an essay on the Edomites.
3. How many people of the name 'Obadiah' are mentioned in the Bible? Name those that are discussed in this lesson.
4. Write on the date and historicity of Obadiah.
5. Write the summary of this book.
6. Name the transgressions of Edom.
7. What are the variants of the name 'Obadiah' and what does it mean.

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LESSON 10

Jonah

Objective : To understand the life of Jonah- the first missionary who was sent out by God to a distant land to lead them to repentance whose life exemplifies the death and resurrection of Christ.

Memory Verse :

Jonah 2:8,9 – “Those who regard worthless idols Forsake their own Mercy. But I will sacrifice to You With the voice of thanksgiving; I will pay what I have vowed. Salvation is of the Lord.”

Jonah 4:2 – So he prayed to the Lord, and said, “Ah, Lord, was not this what I said when I was still in my country? Therefore I fled previously to Tarshish; for I know that You are a gracious and merciful God, slow to anger and abundant in lovingkindness, One who relents from doing harm.

Introduction:

Jonah, the prophet, is sent to the city of Nineveh as a messenger declaring the judgement and the grace of God. Nineveh is the capital city of the Assyrian empire, which ruled the world for a total of 300 years. The size of Assyria is somewhere around the division of Israel into two. It later destroyed the northern kingdom of Israel.

Assyrian Kings who oppressed Israel and Judah

- | | | |
|--------------------------------|------------|--|
| 1. Shalmaneser 3 rd | BC 860-825 | started the task to destroy Jerusalem |
| 2. Adad Nirari 3 rd | BC 808-783 | oppressed Israel and took tribute from them. It was during this time that Jonah visited Nineveh. |

3. ThiglathPilazer 3 rd	BC 747-722	Access to the seaport was denied
4. Shalmanesser 4 th	BC 727-722	Defeated Samaria
5. Sargon 2 nd	BC 722-705	Those who still remained were taken as prisoners (period of Isiah)
6. Sannaeharib	BC705-681	defeated Judah (time of Isiah)
7. Esae-haddon	BC 681-668	strong
8. Assur- Bani pal	BC 668-626	strong & wicked
9. 2 weaker kings	BC 626-607	Assyrian empire comes to an ends

Jonah

It's no surprise that Jonah was unwilling to obey God through fear and preach judgement to a people who vehemently tried to destroy his land. The oppression and troubles faced by the people for generations from the hand of Assyria were great. Jonah led the people of Nineveh to repentance, but moreover, he himself was led to repentance and grew in faith (Lk. 11:30). We are brought to the realization that God is very interested in the affairs of all nations.

The name 'Jonah' means 'dove'. Jonah's house is in Gath Hepher, near Nazareth (2 Kin. 14:25). He is of the tribe of Zebulun. Jonah was a sign (Matt. 12:39-41). Because of his prophecy, Israel remained in bondage for a while longer, since Nineveh repented and God had grace on them. Jonah was a prophet of Israel. He lived during the time of Jeroboam II. It was a time of prosperity. We know more from the book about himself. What prompted him to disobedience was if Nineveh repents, God will have compassion on them or love for oneself or his enmity towards Nineveh or even irresponsibility. To treat his rebellion, God threw him into the sea where a giant creature of the deep swallowed him up. God taught him a lesson about God's seriousness towards His commandments and His Word.

Gath Hephar is to the west of Galilee and three miles north is Nazareth. It may be that the Pharisees forgot about Jonah when they

said, “Look at the scriptures, no prophet has ever risen from Nazareth (or around it)” (John 7:52). Jonah is from Galilee. Jewish tradition claims that Jonah is the son of the widow of Zarephath, whom Elijah raised to life. (1 Kin. 17:8-24).

The Hebrew form of ‘Jonah’ is ‘Yonah’. In Greek, the term ‘Ionas’ is used, and in Latin, the term ‘Jonas’ is used.

Nineveh

The original city was 3 miles long and 1½ miles in width. But including the greater Nineveh – Calah, 30 miles south and Khorsabad, 10 miles north, the total land – shaped like a triangle – included the land between the rivers Tigris and Zaab, and was surrounded by walls all around.

Calah is the southern boundary of Nineveh. Around 1000 acres of land is included in this region. Archaeologists excavated the remains of the palaces of Ashur Banipal, Shalmanezar, Tiglath Pilezar, and Esarhaddon.

When excavating Khorsabad, archaeologists found the remains of the palaces of Sargon and Sennacherib. Both the palaces were very magnificent, but Sennacherib’s palace was better than Sargon’s palace. Adad-Nirari iii, son of Shamshi-Adad v, was a young ruler and so, Semiramus acted as the regent. It was during this time that Jonah preached his message to Nineveh.

Mount of Jonah

Among the remains of Nineveh was found the tomb of the prophet Jonah. This tomb (mount) is called ‘Yunash’. The tomb is situated within 40 acres of land and lies 100 ft above the surrounding plateau. This shows the affluence of the Assyrians. Since the tomb is considered sacred, archaeological workers are limited.

Nineveh was established by Nimrod. After the flood of Noah, we find both cities of Babylon and Nineveh on either side of river Euphrates – Babylon to the south and Nineveh to the north. Both are enemies to each other. Nineveh gained world power in the 9th century. The people of the land were very cruel and wicked. God sent Jonah into the city to forwarn them about the coming destruction if they do not repent. Later,

they attacked Israel and destroyed it (BC 721). 100 years later, Nineveh itself was defeated and captured.

Joppa – Tarshish

Jonah, after turning away from God's call, went to Joppa, the port city (Jonah 1:2,3). From there, he went to Tarshish, a trading port in Spain. While Nineveh was 500 miles southeast of Joppa, Tarshish was 2000 miles west of Joppa, in the Mediterranean sea. How graciously did God halt this flee of Jonah! 800 years after Jonah, we see Peter residing in Joppa.

Sea creature

We are not aware of what type of sea creature swallowed Jonah. Some say that it is a whale. Various translations suggest the term 'sea monster'. There are creatures in the deep which are able to swallow a man whole. The Greek word used is 'ketos.' It is obviously not the whale. Yet this story is incredible, but not everyone accepts it. They argue for a figurative story or an example. Yet the modern world has seen sea creatures 70 ft long and have seen human remains in their stomach. More than a creature swallowing a man whole, the miracle is a man kept alive for three days until he is vomited onto the shores of the Mediterranean sea.

Is the book of Jonah historical?

Many consider it to be a myth or a meaningful story. Jesus Christ mentioned it as a real story (Matt.12:39-41). He calls it a sign of his death and resurrection. We can also accept it as an inspired Word of God. Jonah was a true prophet (2 Kin. 14:25). This story is filled with supernatural elements – large sea creatures, the whole city of Nineveh come to repentance, all this happens during the reign of Jeroboam ii, king of Israel. The layout of the city is also accurate. The use Christ made of Jonah's accounts implies that Jesus considered it to be historical (Matt. 12:39,40; Lk. 11:29-30). This is not a riddle, but scholars have called it a 'honeycomb'. Josephus the historian mentions this particular book. The book of Jonah denotes the salvation of the Gentiles (Rom. 11:25-26). During the millennial rule, the Jews and Gentiles will come together (Zech. 8:7-23).

Author

Jonah 1:1 mentions the author of this book. He lived during the reign of Jeroboam ii, king of Israel (2 Kin. 14:25).

Date and historicity

This book was written in the reign of Jeroboam II, king of Israel (BC 793-753, 8th century – 2 Kings 14:25).

Christ in Jonah

In Mt. 12:39, we read of Christ mentioning Jonah as an example of what he will undergo. Just as Jonah spent three days in the stomach of a sea creature, Christ will spend three days in the earth. Just as Jonah was vomited onto the shore, Christ resurrected from the dead. Jonah paved the way for the salvation of humanity. Jonah was in the stomach of the sea creature for three days. Similarly, Christ will be in the earth for three days.

Main Theme

The awakening of Nineveh and similarities with Christ

Book of Jonah – Summary

Jonah is both the message and messenger. Jonah is unique among the prophets since the message is for the gentile nation. God is interested in the affairs of both the Israelite kingdom as well as the gentile nations.

While the storm, the merchants, sea creature, people of Nineveh, the ivy, the worm, and the east wind all obeyed God, the prophet refused to do so. God teaches repentance and humbleness through His lessons.

The book of Jonah can be divided into two parts, as follows:

1. Jonah's fulfillment of the first call (chapters 1,2)
2. Jonah's fulfillment of the second call (chapters 3,4)

Jonah's fulfillment of the first call.

Chapters 1 and 2 points to God's calling on Jonah to travel to Nineveh and his disobedience (1:2,3). God punishes Jonah for his

disobedience (1:7-14). Jonah didn't like the message to be delivered to the people of Nineveh. Jonah might have thought that God was helping the enemies of the people of Israel. Therefore, Jonah thought it better to travel 2000 miles to Tarshish than to travel 500 miles to Nineveh. God decided to deal with Jonah's rebellion through many sufferings and pain yet covered him with grace and protection.

God told the sea creature to vomit Jonah on dry land. Jonah, on the other hand, realized the sovereignty of God and became strong in faith. He sang a hymn while in the stomach of the creature (ch. 2). He also sang many other psalms (Ps. 3:8; 31:22; 69:1; 92:7). He thanked God for his protected prayer room (stomach of the creature – 2:9). "Salvation comes from the Lord," said Jonah. Jonah surrendered to the will of God after he was regurgitated from the stomach of the creature. As he travelled to Nineveh, he might have thought about his near-death experience.

Jonah's fulfillment of the second call

Jonah accepts God's call (3:1-4). He became a sign for the people of Nineveh (Lk. 11:30). His skin would have been burned by the stomach acids of the sea creature. The people of Nineveh repented on hearing Jonah's call to repentance. There might not have been another message before or after Jonah, to which so many people responded wholeheartedly. Every living creature – from the palace of Adad-Nirari iii and his regent Semiramus to the commoners and cattle – fasted and repented. God was ready to show mercy (3:10) and He didn't allow the calamity to happen.

The grace of God covers the anger and uncompassionate nature of Jonah. Though there was such a response to his message, he was not content. Jonah was angry because of the grace God shows to the Ninevites. Through the example of the ivy, the worm and the east wind, God teaches Jonah to be compassionate.

Jonah became angry (4:1). Because God was compassionate, Jonah said that he did not want to live (4:3). He found joy in the shade of the ivy (4:6). He was dejected because the ivy died (4:8). He was more compassionate to the ivy than to the one hundred and twenty thousand people of Nineveh (4:11). (Some people opine the one hundred and twenty thousand mentioned is simply the number of children in Nineveh

and not the actual population of more than six thousand people. Jonah did not have compassion even on the children).

The repentance of Jonah was greater than the repentance of Nineveh.

This Book has 4 chapters and 48 verses.

Questions

1. Elaborate on the message of Jonah.
2. Name the Assyrian Kings who oppressed Israel. What were their brutalities?
3. Write short note on Jonah, Nineveh, Sea-Creature, Joppa, Tarshish.
4. Find out whether the Book of Jonah is historical or not.
5. How does Jonah represent Christ?
6. Write a summary on the Book of Jonah.
7. Why do we say that, 'The repentance of Jonah was greater than the repentance of Nineveh'?

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LESSON 12

Micah

Objective : We must lead a righteous life before God in this world, for God who opposes oppression of the poor by the rich and the politically powerful will judge them.

Memory Verse :

Micah 6:8 – 8 He has shown you, O man, what is good; And what does the Lord require of you But to do justly, To love mercy, And to walk humbly with your God?

Micah 7: 18 – Who is a God like You, Pardoning iniquity And passing over the transgression of the remnant of His heritage? He does not retain His anger forever, Because He delights in mercy.

Introduction:

Micah is derived from the names ‘Micaiah’, ‘Milka-yah’, ‘Michayahu’ which means “who is like God.” Micah was born in Moresheth near the Philistine city Gath (Micah 1:1, 14-15). Micah ministered in the southern region at the times of Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah. Samaria was occupied by the Assyrians. Assyria became a growing threat to Judah. Micah was in the same time as Isaiah, Hosea, and Amos. Micah prophesied to Israel and Judah. The capital cities Samaria and Jerusalem became victims to the wrath of God due to the unholiness and injustice of the kings, priests, and the prophets. In Jeremiah 26:18, we are able to see Micah at the time of Hezekiah. It was the time of great revival and Passover. We don’t know a lot about Micah’s background. He was called as a prophet from a poor family. He shone in his ministry from the time of King Jotham. Micah, an ordinary villager, fought for justice in the community where he spoke for the poor community. Moresheth is 25 miles south west from Jerusalem and God advised these cities to save themselves from God’s anger. Because they did not obey, God used Assyria to reprimand.

Prophetic style:

Micah wrote in an ordinary and simple style. He fought vehemently against sin (Micah 1:5; 2:1-2). Though the thoughts are reasonable, it’s not arranged properly. A lot of metaphors and imagery can be found (Micah 1:5; 2:4-9). God’s love, mercy, and righteousness is evident everywhere. The word “hear” is prominent in his prophesies. Similar words with the same meaning can be seen frequently throughout the book. The religious background of Micah is similar to Isaiah (Micah 1:1, Isaiah 1:1). The prophesies of Micah are very much similar to most other prophesies (Micah 4:1-6 = Isaiah 2: 2-4). Jeremiah mentions Micah in his book (Jeremiah 26:18). Jesus quoted Micah’s words in Matthew 10: 35,36 and in Matthew 2:6, the prophesy of Jesus is fulfilled.

We can divide the book of Micah into three parts. The first part is advising his people to turn back from evil. The second part speaks about God’s judgement to those who do not repent. The third part talks about the promise of rejuvenation to them that obey the commandments of God.

Micah is derived from the names ‘Micaiah’, ‘Milka-yah’, ‘Michayahu’ which means “who is like God”. The prophet himself gives the meaning of his name (7:8). The Greek term is “Michaias” and the Latin term “Micah”.

The Author:

This prophet from Moresheth may have been a farmer. Moresheth was a farming community. Micah was not politically involved like Isaiah and Daniel but even so he was involved in the lives of hardworking commoners. The reason for Micah’s calling is written in 3:8. Therefore, we can believe that the author of this book is Micah.

Date of Authorship and Historicity:

From Micah 1:1, we can understand that Micah began prophesying at the time of Jotham, King of Judah. Jotham (BC 739 to 731), Ahaz (BC 731-715), and Hezekiah (BC 715-686) reigned in this time. Micah prophesied to the northern and the southern regions. His message was a foresight of the slavery by the Assyrians. Micah’s ministry may have played a role during the reign of Hezekiah.

After Uzziah’s prosperity, Jotham his son reigned in his stead. Jotham was a good King nevertheless he did not turn from evil. Therefore, his son Ahaz was a cruel king. Shortly after he took the reign of the kingdom, Assyria and Syria began attacking Judah. Ahaz’s successor, Hezekiah was strong enough to stop the Assyrians. God also helped in this matter. Hezekiah turned Judah back to God. During the time of Micah, Israel completely strayed from God. The reigns of the Assyrian kings Tiglath-Pileser III, Shalmaneser V, Sargon II, and Sennacherib made Assyria very strong. They would conquer Israel and posed as a threat to Judah. Later, Babylon would overpower Assyria. Micah prophesied that Babylon will attack Judah and make them slaves (Micah 4:10). This was the timeline of Micah’s life. It is believed that he died and was buried in his hometown.

Christ in Micah:

A prolific prophet of the Old Testament, Micah prophesied about Messiah, his reign, and his birthplace 700 years before (Micah 5:2).

When Herod inquired of the high priests where the Messiah was born, they quoted Micah (Matthew 2:5,6). Micah makes known of the Messiah's righteous and eternal rule in Micah 2:12,13; 4:1-8; 5:4,5.

Main Theme:

The prophesy of Messiah being the grace of God to Israel and Judah.

Summary

Micah was a part of a despised and oppressed nation. He spoke against the collective sins of the community. False prophets, priests, and leaders fell as victims before Micah's messages. God was calling his people, through the prophet, to save them from God's punishment (Micah 1:2; 6:1,2). God affirms his people that if they repent, God will cast their sins into the deepest sea and will show them His faithfulness.

We can divide Micah's prophesy into three parts:

Chapters 1-3 – Prophesy of judgement

Chapters 4,5 – Rejuvenation

Chapter 6,7 – Call to repentance, blessing

Prophesy of Judgement

The judgement of Samaria and Jerusalem, the punishment of both cities due to immorality. There are many hidden meanings in this book. The prophets lament due to the judgement which will strike Judah (Micah 1:10-16). Judah is punished because of their cruelty and selfishness. The remnants of the judgement will be gathered (Micah 2:12,13). Moreover, in Chapter 3:1-4, Micah speaks of the judgement which will come on the kings and the princes. In verses 5-8, Micah speaks about the judgements of the false prophets. Finally, in verses 9-12 Micah speaks about the judgement which will come to pass.

Rejuvenation

Chapters 4 and 5 deliver a message of hope to God's people. These chapters contain the establishment of nations (Micah 4: 1-5), the

prophecy of slavery and destruction (Micah 4:6-5:1), and comforting words about the remnants (Micah 5:2-15).

Call to Repentance, Blessing

God calls his people to himself. If they disobey, they will be punished. Even so God shows long suffering and patience. God overlooks their unholiness and wickedness and shows grace. God leads the people who repent into new relationships and blessings.

Micah consists of seven chapters and hundred and five verses.

Questions

1. How do we realise Micah as a prophet who prophesied against the unjust community?
 2. List the names from which “Micah” is derived.
 3. Why is Micah considered a prophet for Israel and Judah?
 4. Describe the prophetic style of Micah.
 5. List all the prophets and kings alive at the time of Micah.
 6. What was Micah’s prophetic summary?
 7. Prove how this prophecy impacted the modern world.
 8. Describe the similarities and differences between Micah and other prophets of his time.
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LESSON 11

Nahum

Objective : There will be judgement to those who turn back to sin even after repentance. The great city of Nineveh heeded the message of Jonah and repented but quickly fell back to sin. The message of God’s judgement is brought by Nahum. The Ninevites became subject to God’s wrath.

Memory Verse :

Nahum 1:7,8 – The Lord is good, A stronghold in the day of trouble; And He knows those who trust in Him. But with an overflowing flood He will make an utter end of its place, And darkness will pursue His enemies.

Nahum 3:5-7 – “Behold, I am against you,” says the Lord of hosts; “I will lift your skirts over your face, I will show the nations your nakedness, And the kingdoms your shame. I will cast abominable filth upon you, Make you vile, And make you a spectacle. It shall come to pass that all who look upon you Will flee from you, and say, ‘Nineveh is laid waste! Who will bemoan her?’ Where shall I seek comforters for you?”

Introduction

The name Nahum means “comfort”, “compassionate”, or “consolation”. There was a gap of over 100 years between Jonah and Nahum. Nineveh found favor with God through Jonah’s message. The message of Nahum was of destruction. Both prophets prophesied about God’s work on the people. The mercy of God and judgement of God was evident in the messages of both the prophets.

Nahum

We know about the background of Nahum. We are acquainted to Nahum as a man from Elkosh (Nahum 1:1). The city Capernaum is named after Nahum, this means “the town of Nahum”. We believe the city, Capernaum, is named so because, either the prophet was from that city or the city was named after the prophet. Capernaum was a prominent place in Jesus’ ministry. It is believed that Elkosh is near Capernaum but, it is debated.

16th century historians believe that Elkosh is north of the bank of Tigris in Nineveh (Al-Qush) in current day Iraq.

Father Jerome opines that it is Elkesi, a city in Galilee, near Ramah. Because of pronunciatinal differences Elkesi became Elkosh. Allegedly, Nahum’s tomb is located here.

Most thinkers consider Elkosh as the city in the southern region of Judah known as Elcese. This city is between Jerusalem and Gaza. This may be the reason why Nahum is considered to be of the southern region. It is also believed that the influence of this prophet is major in the success of Judah (Nahum 1:15; 2:2). Nahum was a prophet and a talented and blessed poet. The destruction of Nineveh and God's judgements is written as deep works of poetry.

Nahum is a shortened form of Nehemiah. The destruction of Nineveh brings satisfaction to the Judeans. The judgement of Nineveh is a great example of the people who disobey God. The Greek term for the name "Nahum" is "Naoum" and the Latin term stays "Nahum". Nahum, Zephaniah, Jeremiah, and Habakkuk were of the same period.

Nineveh at the time of Nahum

Nineveh was the capital city of Assyria. It was the world super power for about 900 years. It fought, conquered, and destroyed Israel. The prophet Jonah was sent to this city and as a result they temporarily repented. Nineveh increased in unrighteousness, selfishness, and cruelty. The city only lasted a hundred years thereafter. The wickedness of the city was intense. The city is symbolized as a lion's cub seeking to prey on the nations and the wealth of the world (Nahum 2:11-13). The city found pleasure in the blood of the people of the world. Therefore, Nineveh was quickly destroyed. The book of Nahum is known as the Nineveh's death song. It is also described as the cry of humanity for justice.

Nineveh fell to the Babylonian force twenty years after Nahum (BC 612). The Babylonian – Median army barricaded Nineveh for two years. Shortly thereafter Tigris began to flood and the mighty walls of Nineveh fell (Nahum 2:6).

The Babylonians and Medes rushed into the city and looted and burned it (Nahum 2:3-4; 3: 1-7). Nahum's prophecies came true. The blood-thirsty city of Nineveh was wiped off the face of the Earth. The Babylonian king, Nebopolassar and the Median king, Cyaxares joined forces to destroy Nineveh.

The mighty Assyrian emperors were Sargon, Sennacherib and Assur Bani-Pal. Assyria enjoyed its golden era under these emperors. It is to

be doubted whether there were any city walls which were stronger than the wall of Nineveh. It was 100 feet in height and its breadth was such that three chariots could be ridden on the wall side by side. Moreover there were towers on these walls which were themselves 100 feet in height. Around the wall there was a moat which was 150 feet wide and 60 feet in depth. The defensive mechanism of the city was magnificent. And so it could withstand any siege. Therefore, it was difficult to believe the prophecy of Nahum that the city would be destroyed. The successors of Ashur Bani-Pal, Ashuretilani (BC 633-629) and Sinsharishkun (BC 619-612) were weak rulers. It was during their time that the Babylonian-Mede armies laid the siege on the city. While the city was under the siege, there was a massive flood on the River Tigris. It was the flood that breached the wall, giving access to the enemy to enter the city. It was completely destroyed (3:11). This happened in BC 612. Even the location of the city could not be identified till AD 1842.

Before 1842, it was thought that the story of this city was a myth. But later archeological excavations dug out the remains of the city and also the history it held – its palaces, period of reign, names of the emperors, etc. The book of Nahum also gained authenticity. In AD 1849-50, under the leadership of Archeologist Layard, a research was done and the library of Ashur Bani-Pal was uncovered. In AD 1852 – 54, researchers Rassam and Rawlinson discovered the library of Sennacherib and the major discoveries are found in the British Museum today. Among the antiques in the library of Ashur Bani-Pal were a collection of items that were actually of 2000 years before the emperor and which are of immense value today. It is a treasure for modern day researchers.

Author

Nahum 1:1

The Historicity of the Book (BC 7th Century)

The destruction of Nineveh is compared with the destruction of 'No Amon' (the city of Thebes in Egypt – 3:8). This city was destroyed by Ashur Bani-Pal in BC 663. The city of Thebes was also a large city, a very proud and prosperous city. The prophet prophesied that just as 'No Amon' was destroyed, so also Nineveh shall be destroyed. The city of Nineveh was destroyed in BC 612. So the time of writing this prophecy

was between BC 661 and BC 612. The city of Nineveh is addressed as 'City of Blood' (3:1). Though the prophet lived in Judah, yet there is no mention of the king. Most probably, he lived during the evil rule of Manasseh (BC 686-642).

Christ in Nahum

There is no direct mention of Christ in this book. Yet the description mentioned in 1:2-8 are the qualities of Christ. There is the trail of Christ's work, judgement and second coming throughout the book.

Main Theme

The destruction of Nineveh, the restoration of Judah

Book of Nahum – Summary

When Jonah, the prophet prophesied destruction on Nineveh, the whole city including the king, repented and turned to God. And so were delivered from annihilation. Yet their repentance was short-lived and did not last for a century. They returned to their old way of life -full of pride and wickedness (While Jonah went around in the city proclaiming judgement, Nahum remained at one place). And so God send Nahum with the message of judgement but they turned a deaf ear to the message. And so (1) God planned the destruction of Nineveh, (2) gave an explanation about the coming annihilation and (3) gave them the just punishment.

1. God planned the destruction of Nineveh (Chapter 1)

Nahum gave the detailed characteristics of God – jealous and avenging God, fierce in anger, slow to anger, great in power, will not leave the guilty unpunished, holy, etc. (1:2-7). There was relief among the people of Judah, that God will deal with the Assyrian threat soon.

2. Explanation about the coming Annihilation (Chapter 2)

God will restore Judah with the destruction of Assyria (2:1,2). Description of the destruction of Assyria (2:3-7); the bondage of 'Nineveh' (2:8-13). The clearest of war description can be found in

second chapter. The chariots are put to fire, the residents flee and there is total chaos and soon the city itself is set on fire, never to rise again.

3. God metes out Just Punishment (Chapter 3)

The reason for the destruction can be seen in chapter 3. The city is filled with blood, violence and wickedness (3:1-7). The prophet prophesied that Nineveh's destruction will be like that of 'No Amon' (Thebes), which happened very quickly. The city dwellers took pride in their city wall and never anticipated destruction. But God had declared through his prophet about the coming destruction (3:11-19). God judged the city in such a way that nothing remained.

There are three chapters and 47 verses

Questions

1. Give the variants for the name Nahum.
2. Compare and contrast the ministries of Jonah and Nahum.
3. Where was Nahum born? What are the arguments in relation to determining his birth place?
4. Why is Nahum called a prophetic poet?
5. Write a paragraph on
 - a. Nineveh – a lion cub searching for its prey
 - b. Book of Nahum – a lamentation on Nineveh
 - c. Book of Nahum – cry for Justice
 - d. Nineveh – a city of strong fortress
 - e. Nineveh – city of blood
6. Narrate the destruction of the city and the great collection of treasure.
7. Compare the city of Nineveh with the city of 'No-Amon'.
8. Bring out the Christ in Nahum
9. Summarize the book of Nahum
10. What is the warning that this book gives us?

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LESSON 13

Habakkuk

Objective : Why does God not punish the sinners among his people? Why does God allow the more evil to punish the less evil? God punishes the wicked justly. But the righteous shall live by faith and he will be saved from all punishment.

Memory Verse :

Habakkuk 2:4 – “Behold the proud, His soul is not upright in him; But the just shall live by his faith.

Habakkuk 3:17-18 – Though the fig tree may not blossom, Nor fruit be on the vines; Though the labor of the olive may fail, And the fields yield no food; Though the flock may be cut off from the fold, And there be no herd in the stalls— Yet I will rejoice in the Lord, I will joy in the God of my salvation.

Introduction

The main content of the book is the destruction of Jerusalem, the judgement on Babylon and the righteous one will live by faith. The Babylonians are expanding to the west (1:6), but has not yet reached Judah (3:16). Let us look into what happened to Jerusalem at the hands of the Babylonians. By this time, the moral and ethical standard of the people were disintegrating (2 Kings Chs. 21,22).

- BC 639-608 The great revival of Josiah – Prophet Zephaniah
- BC 626 Assyria is weakened with the Scythian attack
- BC 625 Babylon freed from Assyrian rule
- BC 608 Jehoahaz rules for 3 months – under Egyptian rule
- BC 608-597 Jehoiakim's rule – most wicked rule – Prophet Habakkuk

BC 612	Babylonians attack and destroy Nineveh
BC 606	Babylonians capture Judah – first Babylonian exiles leave
BC 605	Babylonians defeat Egyptians at the battle of Carchemish
BC 597	Jehoiachin's reign of 3 months – second Babylonian exiles leave
BC 597 – 586	Zedekiah's reign – weak and wicked rule – third Babylonian exiles leave
BC 586	Jerusalem is burnt and totally destroyed

Habakkuk saw the fall of Assyria and the growth of Babylon (BC 7th century). God will not let the sinners and transgressors go unpunished. But the righteous will live by faith. Though the people of God fall under his judgement, he will not totally forsake them. The final victory is of the people of God over their enemies.

Habakkuk was a man of integrity and was soft-hearted. He had a great love for his people. He saw himself as a watchman for his people and fulfilled his task faithfully. He raised his concerns to God on the basis of God's holiness and justice. He started brooding over the fact that God gave the rod of punishment for Judah in the hands of Babylon. The answer to his enquiry to God can be found in 2:4. This is the key verse of this book. This can lead to life and death. This verse has been quoted in the New Testament (Rom. 1:17; Gal. 3:1; Heb. 10:38). Since there is a mention of the stringed instrument in 3:19, it is believed that the prophet is a good musician.

Habakkuk means 'to embrace'. The Greek Old Testament spelling 'Hambakoum' suggests a root meaning 'plant' or 'vegetable'. Other than his work as a prophet, nothing for certain of a personal nature is known about him. Tradition makes him a priest of the tribe of Levi and a member of the temple musicians. The apocryphal book 'Bel and the dragon' tells the story as Habakkuk being the son of Joshua, a musician in the temple and also being instrumental in the saving of Daniel in the second distress he faced in Babylon.

It is believed that Habakkuk was of the priestly class along with Jeremiah and Ezekiel. Habakkuk is not a common Hebrew name. The name means ‘to embrace’ and 3:16-19 does justice to his name, when he says, whatever happens he will stick with God. The Greek word is ‘Ambakoum’ and the Latin term is ‘Abacuc’.

Book of Habakkuk – Canonicity

Habakkuk is quoted by many New Testament writers (Hab. 1:5; Hab. 2:4; Acts 13:41; Rom. 1:17; Gal. 3:11; Heb.10:38). Both Jews and Christians accept the canonicity of this book.

Author

The book is known in the name of the author himself. (1:1; 3:1). It is believed that it was Prophet Habakkuk (also a musician) who wrote the book.

Date and Historicity (BC 7th century)

This book must have been written sometime during the rise of the Babylonian empire (BC 620 – 1:5-6). This book follows the pattern and style of the prophets during the pre-exilic period. Scholars call it the ‘death-bed’ prophecy for Judah. Though there were multiple exhortation to repent, the people refused to do so. Realising the hardened condition of the people, the prophet asked God ‘how long will this continue’(1:2). The answer God gives is the coming of the Babylonians (1:6; 2:1; 3:16). There are those who argue whether it is Manasseh’s sin (686-642) or Amon’s sin (642-640) that is mentioned in 1:2-4. It was during their reigns that sin multiplied. But it was Assyria who was powerful during the time of Manasseh and Amon. Moreover, there is no mention of the revival that took place during the time of Josiah in 1:2-4. So it must be during the time of Jehoiakim, who encouraged wickedness and lacked fear of God. This evil period surely demanded God’s punishment (2 Kings 23:34 – 25:5; Jere. 22:17).

Babylon came to the world scene during the time of Nebopolassar (626 – 605). He was the one who destroyed Nineveh, the capital of Assyria. By the time of Jehoiakim, Babylon had become an unconquerable power. Nebuchadnezzar was the successor to

Nebopolassar. In BC 605 he invaded the west and conquered many nations like Egypt, Palestine, etc. This was also the year, he attacked and conquered Judah. He exiled 10,000 Jews to Babylon, those who were affluent and wealthy – those who oppressed the poor. It may be that Habakkuk started his ministry around this time (around BC 607).

Christ in Habakkuk

The word ‘salvation’ is repeated three times in 3:13,18. The name ‘Jesus’ which means ‘Saviour’ comes from the word ‘Salvation’ (Matt. 1:21). “For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the Lord’s glory, as the waters cover the sea” (2:14) denotes the rule of the Messiah, Christ.

Main Theme

The main content of the book is the destruction of Jerusalem, the judgement on Babylon and the righteous one will live by faith.

Book of Habakkuk – Summary

Habakkuk was a free thinker. He was not afraid of threats and saw them as the test of his faith and submitted his issues into the hand of God and waited patiently for God to answer. When he presented a matter into the hand of God, he received answers and these answers made him aware of who God is, his power and also God’s plan, which in turn prompted him to write a psalm (ch. 3). His faith increased all the more in his conversation with God. His trust in God increased. The end result of his faith is the statement – ‘My righteous shall live by faith’.

The book can be divided into two parts.

1. The difficulties that Habakkuk faced (Chs. 1, 2)
2. The tribute (psalm) of Habakkuk (Ch. 3)

The difficulties that Habakkuk faced

The first conversation that Habakkuk had with God is mentioned in 1:1-11. In 1:1-4, Habakkuk asks God, ‘how long will He suffer these people and allow them to do wickedness’. 1:5-11 is the answer that God gives, ‘He is bringing against them the mighty Babylonians with a rod

to punish them'. The prophet calls them 'the strong wind' that comes from the east. This is God's answer to the wickedness of Judah.

This reply prompts Habakkuk into the second conversation (1:12 – 2:20). Why is God punishing wicked Judah with the more wicked and violent Babylon? (1:12 – 2:1). Will not the holy God punish the wicked and idolatrous Babylon? He is waiting for his answer at his guard post (lookout tower). There are five sins/transgressions for which there is a sure punishment from God.

1. Pride, arrogance (1:5-8)
2. Miss the purpose – cheat (2:9-11)
3. Cruelty and violence (2:12-14)
4. Immorality (2:15-17)
5. Idolatry (2:18-20)

God look seriously on the sins of all people. And nobody can escape from the terrible judgement of God. The same sin of Babylon can be seen in Judah also. God will answer in his sovereignty, "But the Lord is in His holy temple; let everyone on earth be silent in His presence" (2:20).

The Tribute (Psalm) of Habakkuk

Habakkuk, the prophet begins by conversing with God, but ends the book with clarity about the purpose of and praise to God – God's character (3:1-3); His might (3:4-12); His plan (3:13-19) and God's wisdom throughout. This experience with God changes him to be more god-fearing, he became more trusting of God and faithful. His demeanour changed from despair to hope – "Yet I will triumph in the Lord, I will rejoice in the God of my salvation!" (3:18).

This book has 3 chapters and 56 verses.

Questions

1. What were the two questions that Habakkuk asked God? Why? What did God answer?
2. Explain on "My righteous shall live by faith". Give the context and meaning of the verse.

3. Prepare a chart to show the historical events in the life of Israel between BC 639 and 586.
4. Explain the canonicity of the Book of Habakkuk.
5. Give the derivation and meaning of the name 'Habakkuk'.
6. What does tradition say about the background of the prophet Habakkuk?
7. Describe the date and historicity of the book of Habakkuk.
8. Bring out Christ in Habakkuk.
9. Write a summary on the book of Habakkuk.

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LESSON 14

Zephaniah

Objective : The Day of the Lord is near and there will be judgement followed by the Lord's reign, beginning of a new dispensation. Those who are of the Lord are blessed.

Memory Verse :

Zeph. 1:14 - 16 – The great day of the Lord is near; It is near and hastens quickly. The noise of the day of the Lord is bitter; There the mighty men shall cry out. That day is a day of wrath, A day of trouble and distress, A day of devastation and desolation, A day of darkness and gloominess, A day of clouds and thick darkness, A day of trumpet and alarm Against the fortified cities And against the high towers.

Zeph. 2:3 – Seek the Lord, all you meek of the earth, Who have upheld His justice. Seek righteousness, seek humility. It may be that you will be hidden In the day of the Lord's anger.

Introduction

Zephaniah is of the royal descent, the fourth generation of King Hezekiah. After the evil rule of Manasseh and Amon, there was a great revival under King Josiah (BC 640-608). The actual revival must have happened in BC 621. Zephaniah played a major role in this revival (2 Chro. 34). Zephaniah prophesied some years before of the coming of judgement on Judah.

Zephaniah means ‘God Conceals’, ‘God Protects’ and ‘Treasured by God’. The prophet prophesied judgement on Judah, Jerusalem and the surrounding nations on the ‘Day of the Lord’. Seeing the immorality and wickedness of the people, Zephaniah exhorts them to repentance before judgement comes (2:1-3). But there will be restoration after the judgement. God will be King of Israel and will rule over the world from Zion. Zephaniah and Joel are the only prophets who prophesied about the ‘Day of the Lord’. The reason why the prophet calls Judah back to seek the face the Lord, is because the ‘Day of the Lord’ will surely come.

Zephaniah is the son of Cushi. The message delivered by Zephaniah paved the way for the revival during the time of Josiah. Though there were outer transformation, as a result of the revival, it was not enough to bring a lasting change in the people and wickedness still prevailed and so there will be judgement. With the conclusion of the judgement, Messiah will come and restore pure worship.

Zephaniah means ‘God Conceals/Hides’. He was born towards the end of the evil rule on Manasseh. And so he was hidden by God. The Greek and Latin version is ‘Sophonias’.

Author

When Zephaniah introduces himself, he goes back four generations. Hezekiah was the King of Judah. He was the great grandson of Hezekiah. This may be reason, he had free access to the court of Josiah. He was a resident of Jerusalem (1:9,10; 3:1-7) because his address was always ‘this place’ whenever he mentioned Jerusalem(1:4). And so Zephaniah, who lived and ministered in Jerusalem, the capital city , is considered the author.

Date and Historicity (BC 7th Century)

It is not difficult to identify the date of this book. The author, himself, has mentioned the date. He prophesied during the reign of Josiah, the son of Amon (1:1). Josiah ruled Judah from BC 640-608. Moreover, 2:13 points to the devastation of Nineveh, which was destroyed in BC 612, and mentioned as ahistorical fact. Therefore, the period of writing should be between BC 640 and BC 612.

The list of sin/transgressions mentioned in 1:1-13 and 3:1-7 is the direct result of the spiritual slumber during the time of Manasseh and Amon.

Josiah ascended the throne at the young age of eight. At the age of sixteen, he took an interest in spiritual affairs of the nation. The first spiritual cleansing started in the twelfth year of his reign (BC 628 – 2 Chro. 34:3-7). He destroyed and burned the altars of Baal and Asherah and also of all foreign gods, their carved images, their incense altars, killed the priests and the people associated with it, the graves of the false prophets were also destroyed. The book of law found by Hilkiah, the priest, from the temple, paved the way for the second spiritual awakening (BC 622 – 2 Chro. 34:8-35). And so it can be assumed that Zephaniah prophesied between BC 630 and BC 625.

Yet with all these spiritual awakenings, Josiah could not wipe out the transgressions committed in their fifty-five years of reign by Manasseh and Amon. This revival was short and too late, for any major change to take place. And so the revival also came to a halt, with the death of Josiah. The people, again, turned to idols and so they got themselves ready to face the ‘Day of the Lord’. Along with Jeremiah and Habakkuk, Zephaniah was one of the last prophet before the exile.

Christ in Zephaniah

Zephaniah give the description of Christ, twice in the book.

At the end of the world, the Lord will sweep all ruins and wickedness into fire (Zeph. 1:3; Matt. 13:41).

Those who worship heavenly bodies will fear. The Sun and the Moon will be darkened and will not give light. The stars will fall from the sky and the heavenly bodies will be shaken (Zeph. 1:5,6; Matt. 24:29).

The Day of the Lord – points to the second coming of Christ. The one who rules after the judgement is the Messiah, the King of Israel.

Main Theme

The Day of the Lord is near. The restoration of Israel and the rule of the Messiah

Zephaniah – Summary

Zephaniah gives a caution about the ‘Day of the Lord’. He sees a vision about the judgement and its consequences – desolation, ruin, darkness, wrath – and then the Messianic rule which leads to true worship and restoration.

It begins with a warning – ‘I will completely sweep away everything...’ (1:2). But ends with a word of comfort – ‘At that time, I will bring you back’ (3:20).

1. The world judgement (1:1-3). Judgement on Judah (1:4 – 2:3)
2. Judgement on the nations round about (2:4 – 15). Judgement on Jerusalem (3:1-7).
3. Events after the judgement and cleansing (3:8-10). Restoration of Israel (3:11-20).

Division of the Book

1. Day of the Lord – Judgement (1:1 – 3:8)
2. Day of the Lord – Salvation (3:9 – 20)

Day of the Lord – Judgement (1:1 – 3:8)

This book begins with the judgement on the world due to the transgression and sin (1:2,3). Then looks into the judgement on Judah (1:4-18). There is a description on the judgement to come and then the prophet looks into the situation of the land being filled with idols and depraved priesthood. Their kings, elders and the wealthy are all corrupt. And so Judah will not escape the ‘Day of the Lord’. There will be fear, desolation and suffering and then a reprieve for the people to repent, yet there will not be many (2:1).

Therefore God is compelled to judge Judah and the nations around it (2:4-15). The prophet points to all the four directions – in the west, Philistia; in the east, Moab and Ammon; in the south, Ethiopia; and in the north, Assyria. And then he look at Jerusalem (3:1-7), who is also following the sins of the nations. She is called to repentance and a turning back but refused to do so (3:2).

Day of the Lord – Salvation (3:9 – 20)

After proclaiming judgement on the nations, we see the prophet change his style (3:8), because the ‘Day of the Lord’ is also the day of salvation. The people are cleansed. They turned to God and those who did are gathered together, redeemed and restored (3:11-20). They rejoice in their Saviour and Redeemer. He dwells among them. This is the rule of the Messiah.

Though the book of Zephaniah starts with judgement as a result of idol – worship and wickedness, it ends with the return of true worship, and the rule of the Messiah.

The Book of Zephaniah has 3 chapters and 53 verses.

Questions

1. What is the main message of this book?
2. What is the role of Zephaniah in the revival that happened during the time of Josiah?
3. How is the meaning of the name “Zephaniah (God conceals/hides)” conveyed in this book?
4. Prove that Zephaniah is the author of this book.
5. Write on the historicity of the book.
6. Why is Zephaniah along with Jeremiah and Habakkuk thought to be the last prophets before the exile?
7. How does Zephaniah visualizes Christ in his book?
8. Write a summary on this book.
9. What are the evidence that Zephaniah gives about the rule of the Messiah?

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LESSON 15

Haggai

Objective : We can feel exhausted even in the Lord's ministry. But encouragement and exhortation can propel us forward. Through the ministry of Haggai, the work of the temple that was lagging, was rejuvenated.

Memory Verse :

Haggai 1:7 – Thus says the Lord of hosts: “Consider your ways!

Haggai 2:6-9 – “For thus says the Lord of hosts: ‘Once more (it is a little while) I will shake heaven and earth, the sea and dry land; and I will shake all nations, and they shall come to the Desire of All Nations, and I will fill this temple with glory,’ says the Lord of hosts. ‘The silver is Mine, and the gold is Mine,’ says the Lord of hosts. The glory of this latter temple shall be greater than the former,’ says the Lord of hosts. ‘And in this place I will give peace,’ says the Lord of hosts.”

Introduction

Haggai is one of the post-exilic prophets. The others are Zechariah and Malachi. Haggai and Zechariah are contemporaries. They prophesied during the time of Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther.

Both Haggai and Zechariah encouraged the building of the temple (BC 520-516). Some one hundred years after the building of the temple and during the building of the wall of Jerusalem, prophet Malachi ministered during the time of Nehemiah.

Period of Ministry of Prophets Haggai, Zechariah and Malachi

BC 536 The altar was constructed in the 7th month and sacrifice offered

BC 535 The construction of the temple began. Sacrifice stopped

- BC 520 Haggai gave the first call to build the temple on the first day of the sixth month
- BC 520 The construction of the temple was resumed on the 24th day of the sixth month
- BC 520 Haggai gave the second call on the 21st day of the seventh month.
- BC 520 Zechariah's first sermon on the 8th month
- BC 520 Haggai third call on the 24th day of the ninth month
- BC 520 Zechariah's vision on the 24th day of the eleventh month
- BC 518 Zechariah's vision on the 4th day of the ninth month
- BC 516 The construction of the temple is completed on the 3rd day of the twelfth month
- BC 515 The feast of Passover was celebrated on the 14th day to the 21st of the first month
- BC 457 Ezra, the scribe, came to Jerusalem
- BC 444 Nehemiah finished the construction of the wall of Jerusalem. Malachi prophesied.

(The order of the Jewish calendar is Nisan, Iyar, Sivan, Tammuz, Av, Elul, Tishrei, Cheshvan, Kislev, Tevet, Shevat, Adar and the first month of Nisan is as our Mid-March to Mid-April. Find out the English calendar months equivalent to these Jewish months).

Haggai had witnessed the glory of both Solomon's temple and the temple of Zerubbabel.

Babylon had captured the kingdom of Judah. They burnt the city (BC 606-586 – 2 Kings 24:25). The people of Judah were in exile for the next 70 years. Cyrus, the Persian King, captured Babylon. The Persian kings were more favourable to the Jews than were the Babylonian kings. Cyrus proclaimed an order favourable to the Jews in allowing them to return to their land and build the temple in Jerusalem (BC 539). As a result, fifty thousand Jews, under the leadership of Zerubbabel, made

their way back to Judah in BC 536. They began the building of the temple, but had to stop after the foundation of the temple was laid. The Jews turned their attention to building their houses. Darius ascended the throne. He was also approving and sympathetic to the Jewish cause. He permitted the construction of the temple to resume. The prophecies and exhortations of Haggai and Zechariah motivated the people to build the temple, which was finished in 4 years (BC 520 – 516). It was 70 years after this that the walls of the City of Jerusalem was finished, under the leadership of Nehemiah.

When Haggai started his prophetic ministry, he must have been at least 75 years of age. He might have been born around BC 586, before the destruction of Jerusalem. He, along with the young man, Zechariah, ministered in Jerusalem, after the exile (Ezra 5:1; 6:14).

The meaning of the name ‘Haggai’ is ‘Festive’. The name is quite possibly derived from the Hebrew word ‘Hagag’ meaning ‘to celebrate’. Some scholars is of the view that ‘Haggai’ is a derivation of ‘Haggiah’, which means ‘Festival of Yahweh’ or ‘Festival of the Lord’. It is believed that he was born during the feast of tabernacles. Some hold the view that his second prophecy was on the day of his birthday. The Greek form of Haggai is ‘Aggaaios’ and the Latin form is ‘Aggaeus’.

Author

The prophet speaks his messages in the third person pronoun. And so some doubt whether a contemporary of Haggai must have written it in his name. But this is the usual practice of the prophets. The author conveyed the messages he received from God in this manner.

The name ‘Haggai’ is mentioned nine times in the book. The literary style and the focus of the subject point to Haggai. This proves beyond hesitation that it was he who wrote this book. Most of the information we have, about the prophet, is what we glean from this book. We also read about him in Ezra 5:1 and Ezra 6:14. He came back from exile along with Zerubbabel and dwelt in Jerusalem. Thus, we can say that it was Haggai who wrote this book.

Date and Historicity (BC 6th Century)

Haggai began his prophetic ministry in the 2nd year of the reign of Darius (1:1). Along with Zechariah, he aroused the returned exiles to the construction of the temple. Though the work of building the temple, started during the time of Cyrus, was halted by the enemies of Judah, it was resumed during the time of Darius. It was completed during the sixth year of his reign. Haggai was a contemporary of Zechariah (Ezra 5:2). The five messages of Haggai are mentioned with the date, month and year (1:1,15; 2:1,10,20). He begins his message with either ‘the word of the Lord came’ or ‘the Lord of Hosts says this’. And it is repeated 19 times in the two chapters.

The construction of the temple was put on hold due to the Samaritans who complained against it to the king. This discouraged the people. They turned their attention to their own houses and fields. Yet the hand of the Lord was not favourable to these people in regards to their houses and fields. All their efforts were in vain. Still the people felt that it was impossible to build the temple without first building the wall around Jerusalem and that it was not time to built the temple (1:2). But with the joint effort of Haggai and Zechariah (through their prophetic messages) and Zerubbabel, the governor and Joshua, the High Priest, the construction of the temple was completed in four years (BC 520 – 516). This was the main focus of Haggai’s ministry.

The prophet, Haggai, gave four divine messages during the 2nd reign of the Persian king, Darius. These messages laid the basis for the canonicity of the book. All the messages are given with date.

Haggai – Zechariah Joint Messages

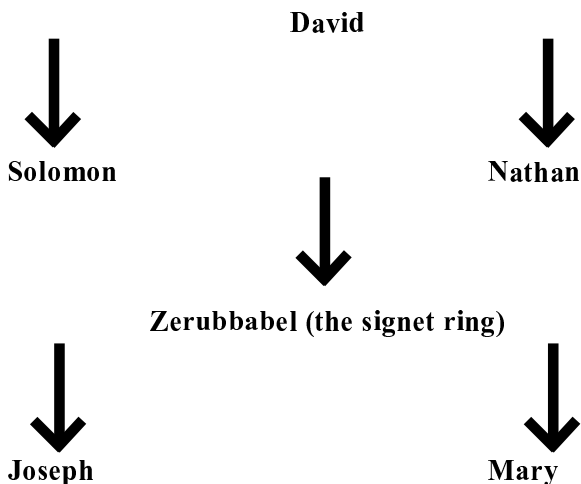
Haggai 1:1	September 1	BC 520
Haggai 1:15	September 24	BC 520
Haggai 2:1	October 21	BC 520
Zechariah 1:1	November	BC 520
Haggai 2:10, 20	December 24	BC 520
Zechariah 1:7	February 24	BC 519
Zechariah 7:1	December 4	BC 518

Completion of the temple – Ezra 6:15 BC 516

Christ in Haggai

The promise received by Haggai (2:9) was the second temple. This was part of the redemptive restorative work of God. Herod, the great, later on beautified this temple. The glory of God (Shekinah) dwelt there.

The Messianic figure can be realised in Zerubbabel – “‘On that day’ declares the Lord of Hosts – ‘I will take you, Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel, My servant’ – the Lord’s declaration – ‘and make you like my signet ring, for I have chosen you’” (2:23). Zerubbabel is a major player in the line of Messiah, just as David is. We find Zerubbabel, son of Shealtiel mentioned in the genealogical order mentioned in Matthew and Luke (Matt. 1:12; Luke 3:27).



Main Theme

The building of the Temple – The encouragement from the prophet

Book of Haggai – Summary

The smallest book of the Old Testament is the book of Obadiah. The second smallest is Haggai. There are four major messages in Haggai. After starting the construction of the temple, the people left off due to

opposition, and started focusing on their own houses and fields. God was not pleased with the people. When they returned to build the temple, God was pleased and blessed them. It was during this period of discouragement among the people, that Haggai stood forth as a true servant of God.

Four Main Messages

Completion of the Temple of God (1:1-15)

The Glory of God in the Temple (2:1-9)

Blessing in Obedience (2:10-19)

Blessings of the future (2:20-23)

Completion of the Temple of God (1:1-15)

Those who came from Babylon, under the leadership of Zerubbabel, started the construction of the temple. It was put on hold due to opposition. They have started building panelled and thatched houses for themselves. The excuse they gave for not building the temple was – “The time has not come for the house of the Lord to be built” (1:2). The people felt that it was impossible to build the temple without first building the wall around Jerusalem (1:1). The people were unable to make ends meet. There was crop failure and they were in deep trouble. Then God send Haggai with the message to concentrate on building the temple and that God will bless them, if they do. Encouraged by the prophets, and Zerubbabel, the governor and Joshua, the High Priest, the people were aroused from their slumber and began the construction of the temple. The work was started on the 24th day of the sixth month of BC 520 (2nd year of Darius) and finished on the 3rd day of the twelfth month of BC 516 (6th year of Darius – Ezra 6:15).

The Glory of God in the Temple (2:1-9)

To the elders who have seen the temple of Solomon, they cried loudly, seeing the modest structure. Jewish Talmud says that the reason for the loud weeping of the people was due to the realization that the Ark of the covenant, Shekinah, Urim and Thummim were absent in this temple (Ezra 3:8-13). Haggai encouraged them by reminding them of God’s promises (2:4,5) and also told them what he will do for them in

the future (2:6-9). This temple will be more magnificent than the temple of Solomon (2:9).

Blessing in Obedience (2:10-19)

He exhorted the priests to obey God and the law. He turned the priests back to God from their wickedness (2:11-13). He also urged the people to return to God (2:14-19). Wickedness, sin, transgressions, violence are all barriers to blessings. When the people humbled themselves and took an interest in the building of the temple, their land also received blessings.

Blessings of the future (2:20-23)

Haggai again prophesied to Zerubbabel. In this message, the judgement of the nations is contained in the first part. The enemies will be overthrown and scattered. Zerubbabel is pictured as the symbol of the coming Messiah. He is the signet ring – the one individual in the post exilic period to be found in the genealogies of Joseph and Mary (Matt 1:12; Luke 3:27).

The Book of Haggai has 2 Chapters and 38 Verses

Questions

1. How does the book of Haggai prove that spiritual exhaustion can be overcome with encouragement and inspiration?
2. Write a paragraph on
 - a. Two of the post-exilic prophets
 - b. Chart on the main historical events in the life of Zechariah and Haggai
 - c. The reason for the entry of Haggai into ministry
 - d. Etymology of the name 'Haggai'
 - e. Authorship of the book
 - f. Haggai – Zechariah Joint Messages
 - g. Christ in the Book of Haggai
 - h. Reason behind halting the work of the temple construction
3. Write on the historical events (historicity) of the book of Haggai.
4. Write a summary on the Book of Haggai
5. Write an essay on, the reason behind the return of the exiles, prophetic fulfilments, the history of the plight of the exiles who had returned, based on the books of Ezra, Nehemiah, Zechariah and Haggai.

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LESSON 16

Zechariah

Objective : To understand the building of the temple, the first and second coming of the Messiah, judgement, restoration of Judah, Millennial vision of the temple, Messiah's kingdom, peace and complete rule of the Messiah from the book of Zechariah.

Memory Verse :

Zec. 8:3 – “Thus says the Lord: ‘I will return to Zion, And dwell in the midst of Jerusalem. Jerusalem shall be called the City of Truth, The Mountain of the Lord of hosts, The Holy Mountain.’

Zec. 9:9 – “Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion! Shout, O daughter of Jerusalem! Behold, your King is coming to you; He is just and having salvation, Lowly and riding on a donkey, A colt, the foal of a donkey.

Introduction

Zechariah is a contemporary of Haggai. Though Haggai is old, Zechariah was a young prophet. Zechariah was the son of Berechiah, and the grandson of Iddo, the prophet and was the member of the priestly family (1:1,7; Ezra 5:1; 6:14; Neh. 12:4; 16:7). He was born in Babylon and since his father passed away early, it was his grandfather, Iddo who brought him up and they returned with Zerubbabel, the Governor and Joshua, the High Priest (BC 539).

It may be due to the fact that his father passed away early that there is no mention of him. Moreover, responsibility must have fallen on his shoulders at a very young age. Though he was young in age (2:4), he was called as a prophet in BC 520. Two years after Haggai preached,

the building of the temple began. During this time, Zechariah also started his ministry. And together they ministered for four years both prophesying to and exhorting the people. Zechariah started his ministry during the 2nd year and 8th month of Darius' rule. Zechariah exhorted the people that more than being engaged in the building work, the people should listen to the voice of the prophets and have a strong steadfast relationship with God.

The visions that Zechariah saw (1:7- 6:8), gave the temple builders the courage to continue the construction. There was the written permission of the Kings of Persia to build the temple (Ezra 5:6). But during this time of Zechariah, they were still waiting for the permission. And so these visions encouraged them, for they were deep and included visions of the future happenings.

More than the books of the other prophets of the Old Testament, the book of Zechariah hold visions of the Kingdom of Christ, and the future of Israel and other gentile nations. Through his visions, Zechariah reveals the coming Messiah and his death, second coming, rule, priesthood, humanity, divinity, humbled state, justification, selling for 30 silver coins, eternal peace, return of the Israelites to the Cross, the judgement by Christ. He speaks clearly about the end times happenings. The last chapters talk about Israel's defeat, the victory of their enemies, the entry of Christ, on the Mount of Olive, on the part of Israel as their defense and final victory, the Mount Olive is split and becomes a plateau (plain land), total annihilation of the enemies, change in the situation of the nation of Israel, the millennial feast of tabernacle and how the people of Israel enter the life of holiness.

The temple reconstruction was finished by BC 516. After the construction, Zechariah gave two more prophecies to the people. He only prophesied for 4 years. The last prophecy was recorded in BC 518. Chapters 9-14 hold prophecies which has no recording of dates. These may have been told after the reign of Darius. Darius I lived between BC 522 and 480. This period is also mentioned in the Book of Zechariah and so there is a possibility that Zechariah actually prophesied for half a century.

The word 'Zechariah' is derived from 'Zkar-Yeh', meaning 'Yahweh remembers'. This thought (Yahweh remembers) is seen

throughout the Book. God remembers the promises he made to the fathers while he blesses the children. The Greek and Latin variants of the name is 'Zecharias'. Zechariah is a prominent name in the Scriptures. There are 29 persons by this name in the Old Testament.

Judean tradition believed Zachariah to be a member of the 'Greater Synagogue' and a keeper of the prophetic scrolls. It is also believed that this was the Zechariah who was killed between the altars (Matt. 23:35).

Author: Prophet Zachariah

There is no difference of opinion on the authorship of the book of Zechariah on chapters 1 to 8. But regarding chapters 9 to 14, there is a dispute about the authorship. Some argue that Zechariah did not write these chapters. Some say it is pre-exilic while others argue it to be post-exilic. The name of the kings of Israel or Judah are not mentioned in the chapters from 9-14. So this is considered as a writing after the exile. In 9:13, there is mention of the sons of Greece, which is thought to be Alexander and his army. The reason for not mentioning the kings of Judah might have been because of his vision of the greater king and his kingdom - Christ and his kingdom. That may be the reason why throughout the book we see the phrase, 'declares/says the Lord'. This is evidence of this being written by one person. The literary style of chapters 1 to 8 is continued in the rest of the chapters. Therefore it is believed that it was Zachariah, the prophet who wrote this book. We can presume that there is a gap of writing between Chs 1-8 and Chs. 9-14.

Date and Historicity

Zechariah was a young prophet and a contemporary of Haggai. Zerubbabel, the governor and Joshua, the High Priest were the political and spiritual rulers of the land. Chapters 1-8 (BC 520-513) hold similarity with the message of Haggai. The context is the building of the temple, which was finished in BC 516. There is no mention of the dates in chapters 9-14. The mention of Greece point to a period of BC 480-470. Darius I ruled from BC 521- 486. Then we have Xerxes (BC 486 - 464) on the throne. It is this King who removed Queen Vasti and made Esther the Queen. And so it is believed that the period of writing this book must have taken place during the reign of Darius I and Xerxes.

Christ in Zechariah

There are many references to Christ and his life in this book. The prophet mentions Christ both as the Servant and the King. He is pictured as truly Divine and truly Human.

The messenger of Yahweh (3:1,2)

Sin Offering (3:8,9; 13:1)

Branch of Righteousness (3:8; 6:12,13)

Stone with seven eyes (3:9)

Builder of God's temple (6:12)

Royal Priest (6:13)

World ruler (6:13; 9:10)

The Humble King, the victorious entry (9:9; Matt. 21:5; John 12:15)

The chief cornerstone, tent peg, battle bow (10:4)

Sold for 30 silver coins – the price of a slave (11:12,13)

Buy the field of the potter (11:13; Matt. 27:6,10)

Good Shepherd (11:4-13)

His Divinity (12:6)

His hands and feet will be pierced (12:10; John 19:37)

Spring of cleaning (13:1)

Shepherd, who is struck (13:7; Matt. 26:31; Mark 14:27)

The coming Judge (Ch. 14)

The King of Righteousness (Ch. 14)

Main Theme

The restoration of Jerusalem, The Kingdom of the Messiah,
The hope of the people of God.

The prophecy of Zechariah – Viewpoint

There is mention of 8 visions, 4 messages, 2 prophecies and the hope of the people of God. The first 8 chapters are related to the building of the temple of God. The next 6 chapters point to the coming of the Messiah. There is a transition from democracy to theocracy to the rule of Messiah. The book moves from persecution to peace from unholiness to holiness.

The book can be divided into three parts

1. Eight Visions (Chs.1-6)
2. Four messages (Chs. 7-8)
3. Two prophecies (Chs. 9-14)

The Eight Visions

The book begins with a plea for the people to repent and return back to God. The book exhorts the people not to be rebellious like their fathers (1:1,6). After a short time, Zechariah saw chain of visions at night. One night he had a particularly painful vision, which the angel interprets for him (1:7 – BC 519, February 15). The vision has relation with the coming Messiah. Through his visions, Zechariah is seeing the plan of God for the future. There are no visions of valleys. The first five visions are visions of comfort and the last three are visions of judgement.

a. Horsemen among the myrtle trees (1:7 – 17)

Myrtle trees are not actually trees but plants. They have white blossoms. The ripe fruits are black in colour. Oil is extracted from these seeds. The Hebrew name of Myrtle is Hadassah, which in turn is the Hebrew name of Queen Esther.

b. Craftsmen with four horns (1:18 – 20)

The enemies of Israel are judged.

c. Man with the plumb line(2:1-13)

God will protect and dwell in Jerusalem in his glory

d. Cleansing of Joshua, the High Priest (3:1-10)

Israel will be cleaned and restored in the day of the Branch (Messiah).

e. Golden Lampstand (4:1-14)

God will strengthen Joshua and Zerubbabel

f. Flying Scroll (5:1-4)

g. Woman in the basket (5:5-11)

h. Four Chariots (6:1-8)

Joshua is crowned as representation of Christ

Four Messages (Chs. 7 and 8)

The question which arose during the time of festivity led to Zechariah receiving four continuous messages:

- a. Rebuke for dead traditions (7:4-7)
- b. Reminding of past disobedience (7:8-14)
- c. Restoration of Israel and hope (8:1-17)
- d. Return of the nation to its long lost joy of being a nation (8:18-23)

Two Prophecies (9-14)

a. First Prophecy (Chs. 9-11)

Israel rejects its King (Christ) in his first coming. A clear description of the cross and suffering is given here. While Alexander, the great began his campaign, he conquered the surrounding cities but leaves Jerusalem alone (9:1-8). It was spared for the coming Messiah (Christ – 9:12-17). Later it was destroyed. But the Messiah will restore and bless them (10: 1-11:3). Israel rejected its true shepherd and went after false shepherds and so was scattered (11:4-17).

b. Second Prophecy (Chs. 12-14)

In his second coming, Israel accepts Christ as their King. The nations of the world will come against Jerusalem. Christ will then appear and save his people (12). They will be cleansed of all falsehood and impurity and will become holy (13). Messiah will come and judge the nations. He will reign as King in Jerusalem and rule the world (14). This is the second part of the second coming of Christ. The prophets did

not have the revelation of the coming of Christ for the Church in the mid-air. The prophecy is about the second coming of Christ with the heavenly hosts and all the saints together from mid air.

This book has 14 chapters and 211 verses

Questions

1. Narrate on the family background of Zechariah
2. Write on the context and the content of the visions that Zechariah had.
3. Bring out Christ in the book of Zechariah
4. Why has the date not been mentioned for the chapters 9-14?
5. Write on the derivation of the name 'Zechariah'
6. How do we know that Zechariah is the author of the book?
7. Write on the historicity of the book?
8. Write on the viewpoint of the book of Zechariah.
9. Elaborate on the two prophecies of Zechariah

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LESSON 17

Malachi

Objective : To understand how in a world of immorality and wickedness, those who fear the Lord are strengthened and prepare themselves to receive the Son of Righteousness while those who continue in wickedness will face the fiery judgement.

Memory Verse :

Malachi 2:17 – 3:1 – You have wearied the Lord with your words; Yet you say, “In what way have we wearied Him?” In that you say, “Everyone who does evil Is good in the sight of the

Lord, And He delights in them,” Or, “Where is the God of justice?” “Behold, I send My messenger, And he will prepare the way before Me. And the Lord, whom you seek, Will suddenly come to His temple, Even the Messenger of the covenant, In whom you delight. Behold, He is coming,” Says the Lord of hosts.

Malachi 4:5,6 – Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet Before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the Lord. And he will turn The hearts of the fathers to the children, And the hearts of the children to their fathers, Lest I come and strike the earth with a curse.”

Introduction

The Book of Malachi is seen by some scholars as the final exhortation for the people to correct their ways. The prophet’s personal life and family are unknown. It is believed that he might have lived one hundred years after Haggai and Zechariah, during the time of Ezra and Nehemiah (BC 450-400). A remnant had returned and under the leadership of Zerubbabel, the governor, Joshua, the High Priest, and Haggai and Zechariah, the prophets, had built the temple (BC 520-516).

Thus by the time of Malachi, one hundred years have passed and the wall of the city of Jerusalem might have been done under the leadership of Nehemiah. But the people still continued in idol-worship. The priests were sluggish in spiritual matters and did not follow the law. The people failed to pay tithes. Both the priests and the common people married women of different nations. They were hypocrites and weak. In this situation, God appointed Malachi to strengthen the remnant, who still adhered to the law and to proclaim judgement and the appearing of the Messiah. Malachi is a contemporary of Ezra and Nehemiah. The focus of the prophet was that people should return to God.

There is reference to John, the Baptist, the fore-runner of Jesus, in this book. Malachi points out to the people that with their impure life style, they have sinned against God and their own family. Yet they question God. And God provides answer to these questions. This is a Jewish literary style.

Though, Malachi prophesied against the ill-practices and impure lifestyles of the priests and the prophets, it was not received well. And so God was silent from the time of Malachi to the time of John, the Baptist, some four hundred years.

The name Malachi comes from “Mal’akhi” meaning “my messenger”. Malachi is the shortened form of “Malakyah” meaning “Yahweh’s angel”. In Greek it is “Malachias” meaning “by the hand of my messenger”. In Latin it is “Maleachi”.

Author

Since the meaning of the name “Malachi” is “my Messenger”, many hold the view that it is a title name and so might not be a historical person. Moreover, the name “Malachias” (Greek) means “by the hand of my messenger”, there is a thought that someone might have used it to write the book – either Ezra or someone might be the writer. But there are those who argue that Malachi was the name of a person and not a title. Furthermore, none of the prophets have used pseudonyms (false names), Malachi also must be the proper name of the prophet (1:1 and 3:1).

We do not know anything about the prophet or his family. Jewish tradition say that he was a part of “the Anshei Knesset Hagedolah”, the Great Assembly that met in the Holy Temple in Jerusalem at the beginning of the Second Temple era.

Date and Historicity

Malachi was a contemporary of Nehemiah. The situation that Malachi found himself in was that the priests and the common men married heathen (gentile) women and divorced their Israelite wives, did not follow the law of Moses, did not pay tithes, served idols and led a immoral life (Mal. 2:11-14 cf. Neh. 13:23-29; Mal. 3:8-10 cf. Neh. 13:10-14).

We are not aware of anything about the author from this book except in 1:8, we glean a message about offering blemished animals as sacrifice to God. Malachi questions the people about it. He asks them ‘Will they offer it to their governor, if not, why do they offer it to God’. This term ‘governor’ speaks about the time in which Malachi prophesied (1:8 cf.

Neh. 5:1-14; Haggai 1:1-14; 2:21 – BC 539 – 333). The land was governed by representatives of the Persian king. These representatives were called ‘Pehah’ or ‘Pechah’. Services in the temple was also carried out (1:7-10; 3:8). Therefore, we can say that this was a period after Haggai and Zechariah. Later on, the priests and the people all followed their own ways and did not adhere to the law of Moses as they should (1:6-8; 2:10-13). Thus we can say that the book must have been written somewhere around BC 455.

Christ in Malachi

God did not speak to the people through a prophet after Malachi till the time of John, the Baptist, a gap of four hundred years. John, the Baptist, pointed out Jesus and said, ‘Behold, the lamb of God’ (John 1:29). Malachi talks about John, the Baptist, the fore-runner of Jesus (3:2-5). The ‘Sun of Righteousness’ mentioned denotes Christ (4:2). Elijah who is to come is the shadow of Christ (Matt.3:3; 11:10-14; 17:9-13; Mk 1:3;9:10,11; Luke 1:17; 8:4; John 1:23). Elijah, the prophet, will also appear before the second coming of Christ.

Main Theme

God answers the Israelites, even when they hide their sins and question Him – the day is coming, burning like a furnace (4:1) – on those who fear God, the sun of righteousness will rise.

Book of Malachi – Summary

Even when the prophesies of Haggai and Zechariah were being fulfilled, people became doubtful and miserable, not having the love for God and many becoming atheistic. Yet the services in the temple continued. They failed to pay tithes and sacrificed animals with flaws. Even the priests were corrupt and tolerant of the evils prevalent in society.

There is a flurry of questions between God and the people

1. “I have loved you,” says the Lord. But you ask, “How have You loved us?” (1:2)
2. ”A son honors his father, and a slave his master. If I am a father, where is the honor due me? If I am a master, where is the respect

due me?” says the LORD Almighty. “It is you priests who show contempt for my name.” But you ask, ‘How have we shown contempt for your name?’ (1:6)

3. “You break the law and do injustice to one another. Yet you ask what injustice.” (2:10-16)
4. You have wearied the LORD with your words.” How have we wearied him?” you ask. (2:17 – 3:6).
5. “Will a mere mortal rob God? Yet you rob me. “But you ask, ‘How are we robbing you?’” (3:7-12).
6. “You have spoken arrogantly against me,” says the LORD. “Yet you ask, ‘What have we said against you?’” (3:13-15).

The people proclaim that they have done no evil. Their rebellion was always hidden and confined. Outwardly they were highly spiritual. Their faith in God decreased as they engaged in their daily tasks. This may be the time of the evolution of the pharisaic hypocrisy. We see hypocritical faith all around. Yet God still loved them and showed them great mercy.

The Book of Malachi can be divided into three parts

1. The position of the people (1:1-5)
2. The wickedness and impurity of the people (1:6 – 3:15)
3. The promise to the people (3:16 – 4:6)

The position of the people (1:1-5)

The people were blind to the love of God. They forgot the miracles that he did in their lives. The prophet reminded them about the ways of Esau and Jacob to strengthen their knowledge of his love for them. They forgot the joy of being loved by God.

The wickedness and impurity of the people (1:6 – 3:15)

The priests offered sacrifices that were blemished, with total disregard for the law of Moses. They did not give as much respect to God as they gave to the Governor, appointed by the Persian king. Since they disregarded the law, and taught it according to their own whims

and fancies and did not follow the law in their life, the priests did not receive the blessings of God.

The men divorced their wives and married foreign women (2:10-16). But instead of accepting their errors, they asked counter questions to God and he gave them two options : (a) judgement for disobedience, (b) Messianic Kingdom for obedience. They robbed God of the tithes and offered blemished animals. God promised prosperity if they respected his messages and followed it whole heartedly (3:7-12). They became selfish and challenged God (3:13-15). The rest of the book is an answer to this challenge.

The promise to the people (3:16 – 4:6)

God gives promises to the people who respect and obey him. For those who forget God, he has prepared a day of judgement, ‘day, burning like a furnace’ (4:1). And to those who obey him, ‘the Messianic days’ are promised. In that day, the difference between those who love the Lord and those who do not love the Lord will be seen. The prophet encourages the people to await the soon coming of the Messiah, in his conclusion.

This Book is having 4 Chapters and 55 verses.

Questions

1. Describe the spiritual depravation during the time of Malachi
2. Write on the authorship of Malachi
3. How does Malachi portray Christ in his book?
4. What are the questions raised by the people to God and vice versa?
5. Why is it said to be the period of the evolution of the pharisaic hypocrisy?
6. Write a summary on the Book of Malachi.

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